



UK Visa Application

A 20-year analysis.

The countries, visa types, policies, and more.



Preface

Migration is one of the defining forces of our time. It shapes economies, communities, and political debates across the world. Among global destinations, the United Kingdom has long held a unique position. Its strong economy, deep historical links to multiple regions, English language advantage, and established legal and educational systems have made it a major hub for migrants seeking opportunity, safety, or connection.

Understanding the UK's visa system is essential for anyone trying to make sense of how migration works today. Over the past two decades, this system has seen major changes, reflecting shifts in national priorities, global events, and public attitudes. From the introduction of the Points-Based System to the impact of Brexit and the tightening of dependant rules in 2024, each change has influenced who can come to the UK, how easily they can stay, and under what conditions.

This report brings together 20 years of visa application and outcome data, covering more than 55.6 million cases across work, study, visit, family, and other

routes. It tracks how migration patterns have shifted over time and across regions. It also highlights the policy decisions that have shaped these trends and their real-world consequences.

Intelpoint has spent years researching visa trends, particularly those of the UK. After producing several short-term insights and focused snapshots, it became clear that a deeper, long-term view was needed. This report is the result: a data-driven resource for policymakers, researchers, institutions, and individuals navigating an increasingly complex global migration environment.

By combining policy context with detailed analysis, this report aims to support smarter decisions and better understanding today, as migration continues to shape lives and nations.



Abiodun Adenle

Research Analyst, Businessfront.

Executive Summary

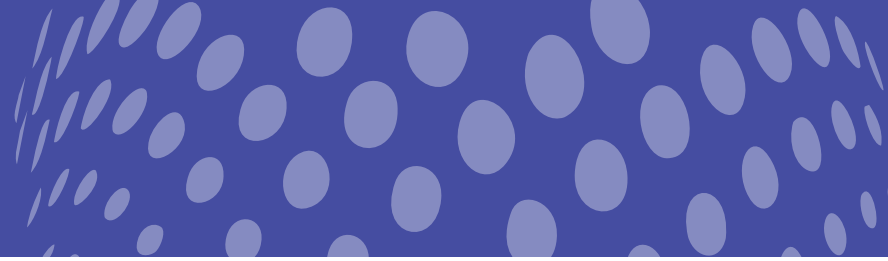
The UK's immigration system has undergone significant shifts over the past two decades, shaped by political decisions, economic needs, and global events. Visa applications have fluctuated in response to policies designed to control migration while addressing labour shortages, university funding concerns, and post-Brexit workforce gaps. Understanding these changes is crucial for students, workers, dependants, and policymakers as they navigate an increasingly complex system.

A detailed analysis of application trends revealed strong seasonal patterns, particularly in study and work visas, where peaks occur in specific quarters each year. These fluctuations align with academic cycles, labour market demand, and policy shifts, reinforcing the importance of using a model that captures both long-term trends and seasonal variations. The UK has experienced a series of peaks and declines in visa applications, with significant increases post-pandemic before a recent downturn in study and work visas. In comparison, Canada has expand-

ed its migration targets, the US remains competitive for skilled workers despite visa caps, and Australia has reinforced its focus on skilled migration. While Canada actively promotes permanent residency pathways, and the US continues processing millions of applications annually, the UK has opted for a more restrictive approach, particularly in recent years, tightening rules on student dependants and low-income workers.

The introduction of the Points-Based System in 2008 fundamentally changed UK migration, replacing previous employer-sponsored work permits with a tiered visa structure. Brexit in 2020 marked another turning point, ending free movement and redirecting visa applications towards non-EU migrants. This shift significantly impacted work and study migration, as businesses and universities adjusted to the new reality of higher fees and increased bureaucratic requirements for European applicants.

Study visas have played a crucial role in UK migration



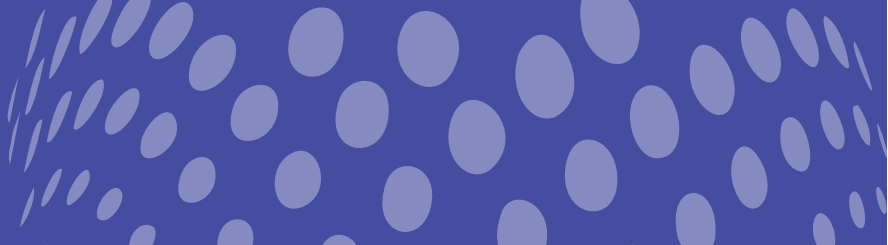
patterns, with applications from China and India consistently dominating. The demand for UK education surged post-pandemic, particularly in 2022, following the reintroduction of the Graduate Route. However, new restrictions implemented in 2024, which prevent postgraduate students from bringing dependants unless enrolled in research programmes, have led to a steep decline in applications, especially from African countries. The UK's attractiveness as a study destination is now being tested as Canada and Australia offer more flexible pathways to work and settlement for international graduates.

Work visa applications have seen considerable fluctuation, largely shaped by labour market needs and government interventions. The Skilled Worker and Health & Care Worker visas have dominated since 2020, largely due to post-Brexit labour shortages and NHS recruitment strategies. In 2022, the UK government expanded the Health & Care visa category, leading to a surge in applications from India, Nigeria, and the Philippines. However, by 2024, new sal-

ary thresholds for skilled workers and restrictions on care workers bringing dependants caused a sharp decline in applications. Nigeria, which recorded an unprecedented 93,000 work visa applications in 2023, saw this number fall to just 29,800 in 2024.

Visitor visa applications have remained relatively stable, with India, China, Turkey, and Nigeria leading in 2024. However, the UK's stricter entry requirements compared to Schengen countries and the US have impacted travel patterns. While visitor visa approvals remain high at 81%, policy changes in 2023-2024 have tightened visa requirements for certain nationalities, resulting in a decline in applications from some regions.

Family visas have consistently played a significant role in UK migration, with Pakistan, Afghanistan, and Syria among the top nationalities applying for reunification in 2024. However, the government's efforts to limit migration have led to increasing restrictions on family visa sponsorships. The financial threshold



for British citizens sponsoring a foreign partner increased to £29,000 in April 2024, making it more difficult for lower-income families to reunite. Additionally, the 2024 ban on care workers and most postgraduate students bringing dependants has significantly reduced applications in these categories.

In the 20-year period, the UK's immigration policy changes were mostly concentrated around the visa framework itself—introducing new visa types, restructuring existing routes, and reforming the overall system. Detention, work, and study routes followed closely, reflecting shifting national priorities on skilled migration and international students. Other areas like settlement and family migration also saw frequent updates, showing the UK's ongoing efforts to tighten, expand, or clarify various aspects of its immigration system.

The launch of the Points-Based System in 2008 redefined how applicants were assessed, leading to new routes like Tier 1 for highly skilled migrants and

later, the Global Talent Visa. Work visa rules were constantly revised, including salary thresholds, settlement eligibility, and sponsorship rules—like the £35,000 threshold introduced in 2016. For students, the shift from Tier 4 to the Student Route brought tighter rules on dependants and course eligibility. Settlement became harder to reach, as seen in the extension of the qualifying period from four to five years and the introduction of “Life in the UK” tests. Detention policies were expanded with new removal schemes and readmission agreements, while asylum and resettlement pathways saw both humanitarian expansions (like the Syrian VPRS) and controversial restrictions (like Rwanda).

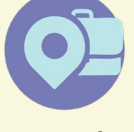
Across all regions, work and study visas were the most reliable, consistently beating the global averages of 92% and 87%, respectively, with especially strong showings in Asia, the Americas, and Oceania. Study visa approvals surged in Africa and Asia, while visitor visa rates declined across the board, dipping below the 84% average. Family visas were

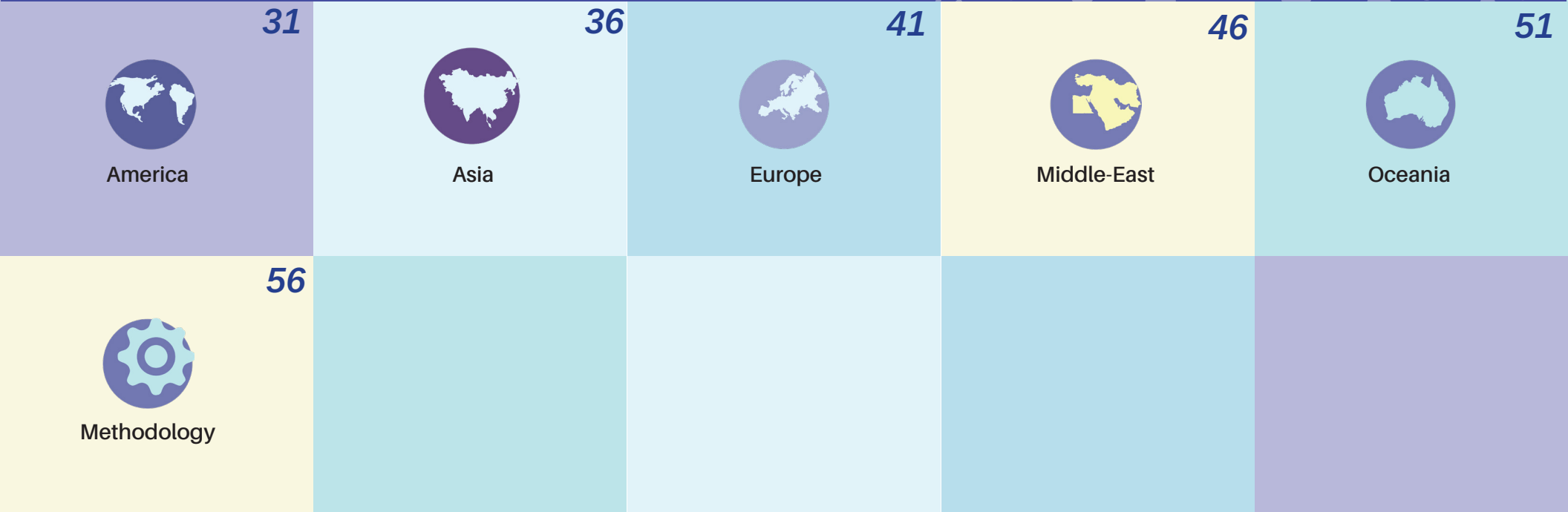


more mixed—some regions saw recovery, others stayed unstable. Other visas, which include transit, creative, religious, ancestry, and other niche categories, showed the most volatility, often falling well below the 81% average due to shifting rules and smaller volumes.

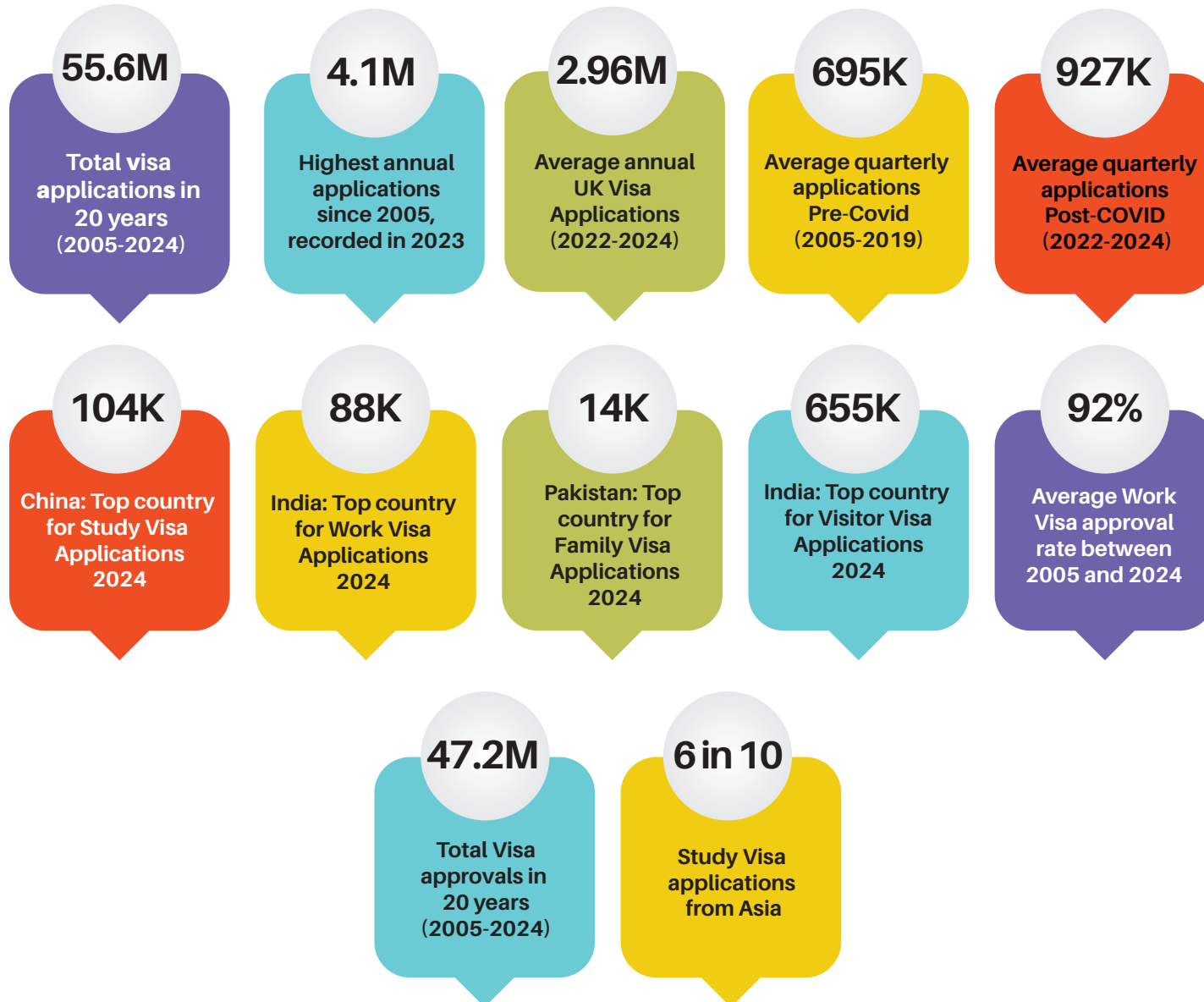
These constant shifts shaped not just how many people entered the UK, but who could come, how long they could stay, and under what conditions they were allowed to build a life.

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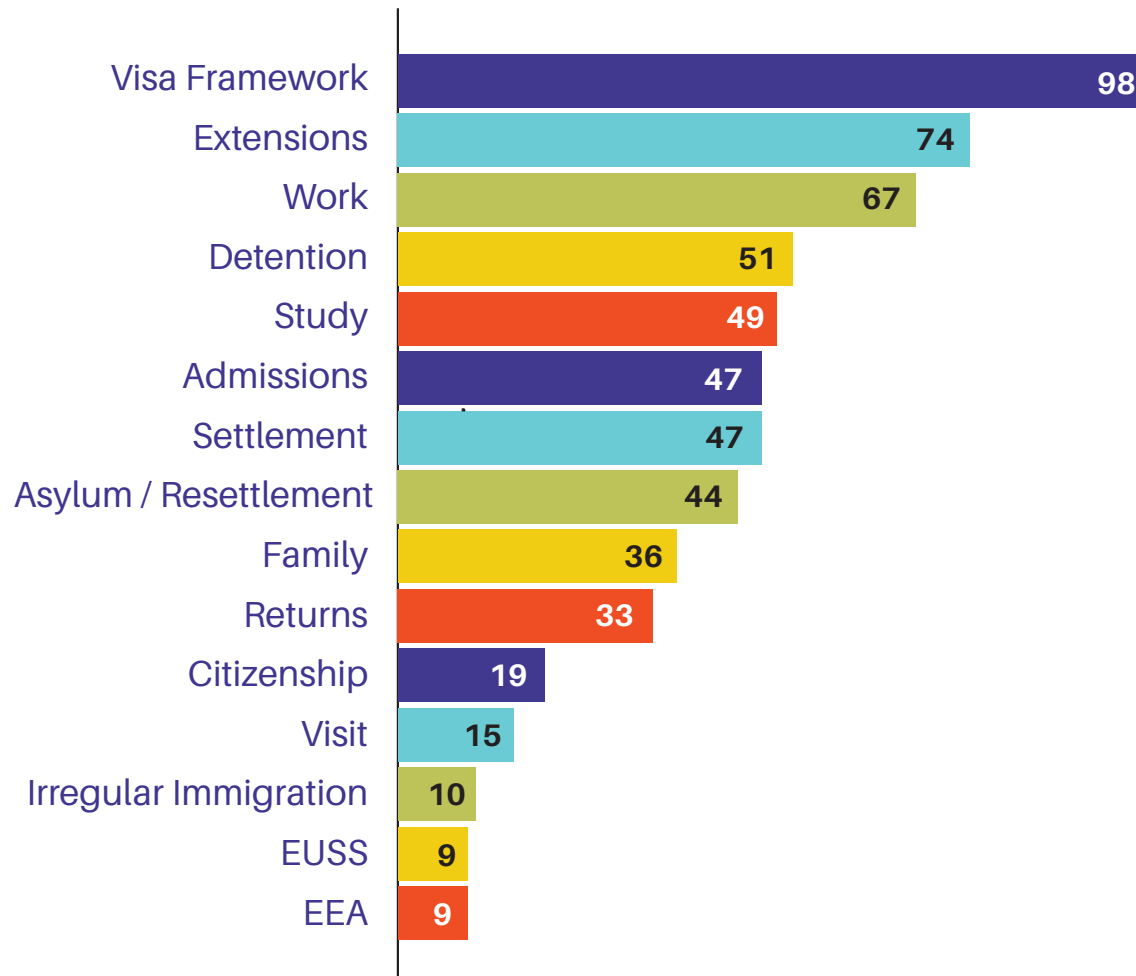


Key Figures



Breakdown of Policy Changes by the UK (2005-2024)

Number of Policy Changes Affecting Each Immigration Category



Visa Framework:

The UK visa framework is the full set of rules that determine who can enter, stay, settle, or be removed from the country, and under what conditions.

EEA (European Economic Area):

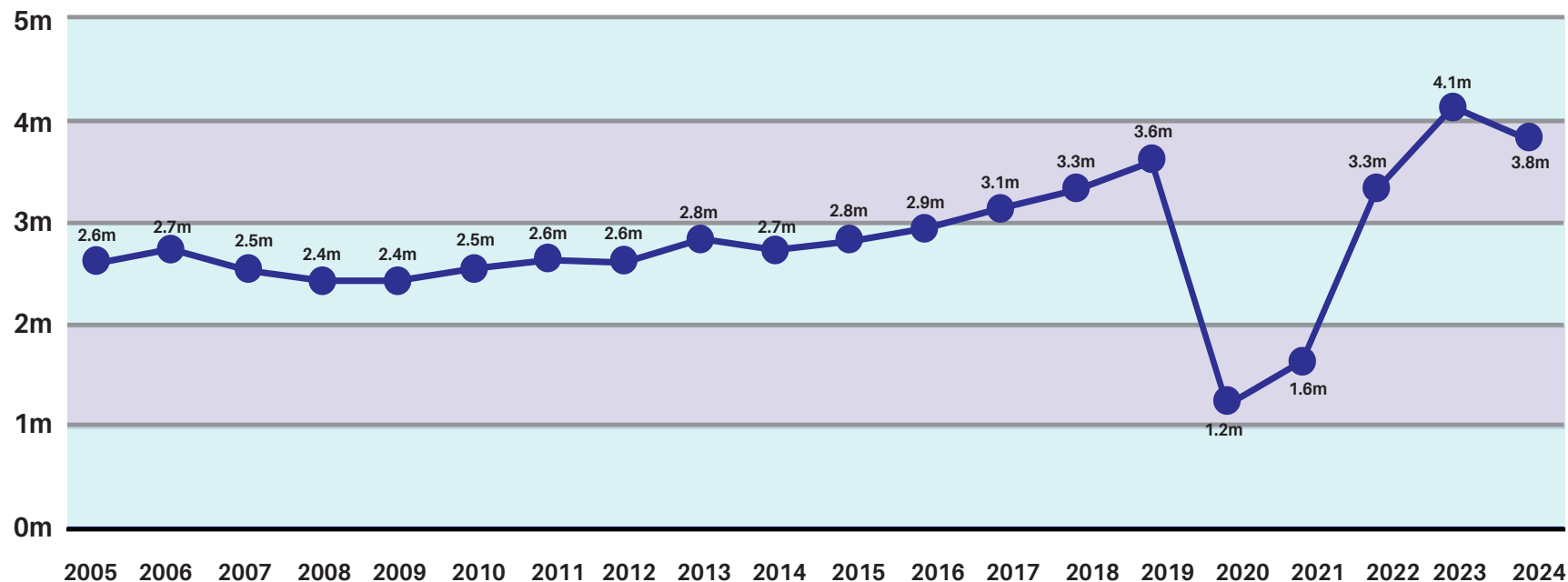
Refers to the rules that applied to EU and EEA nationals before Brexit, including freedom of movement.

EUSS (EU Settlement Scheme):

A scheme that allows EU citizens and their family members who were living in the UK before Brexit to apply for legal status to stay.

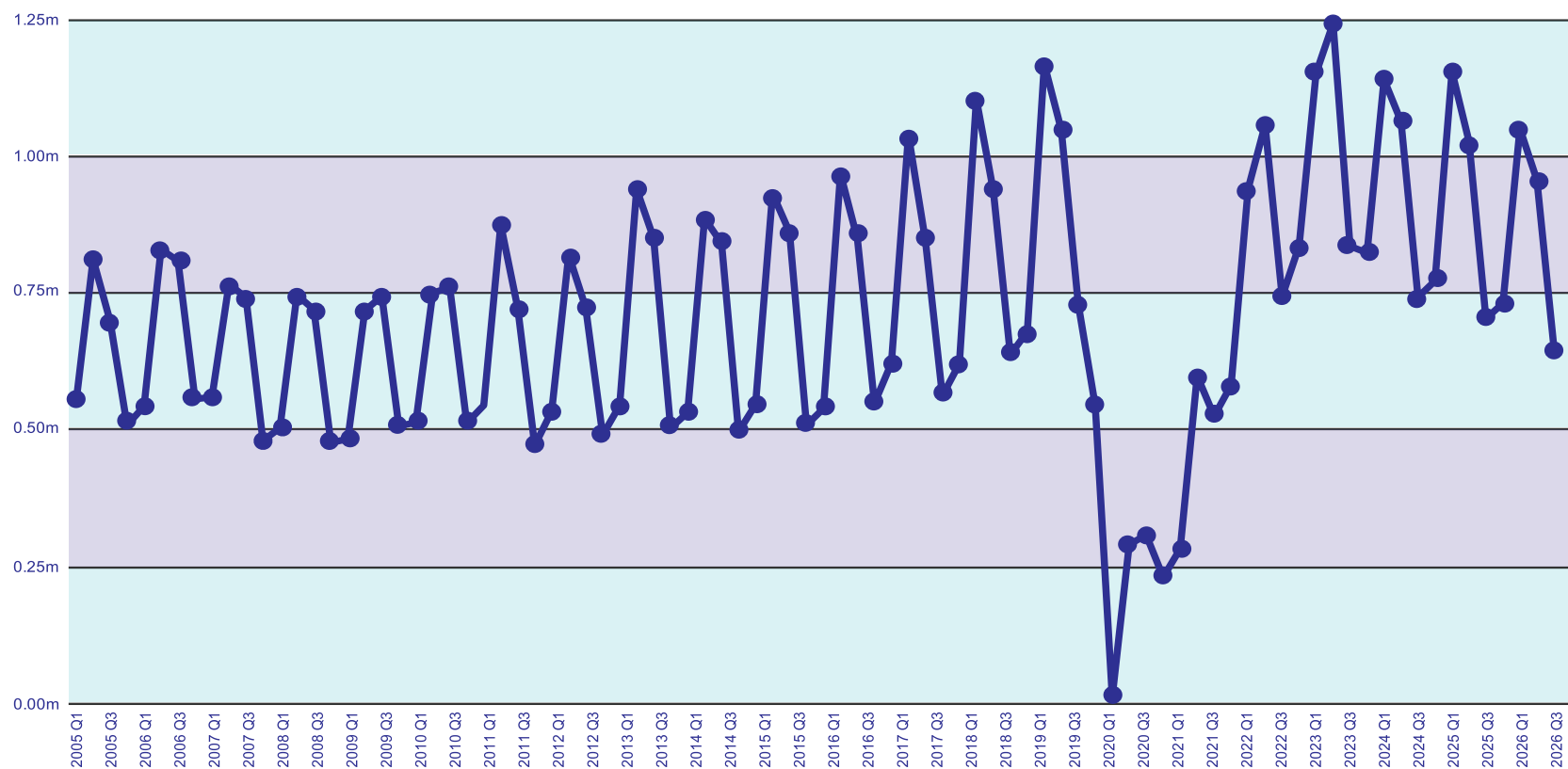
Total UK Visa Applications (2005-2024)

Visa applications surpassed pre-COVID levels in 2023



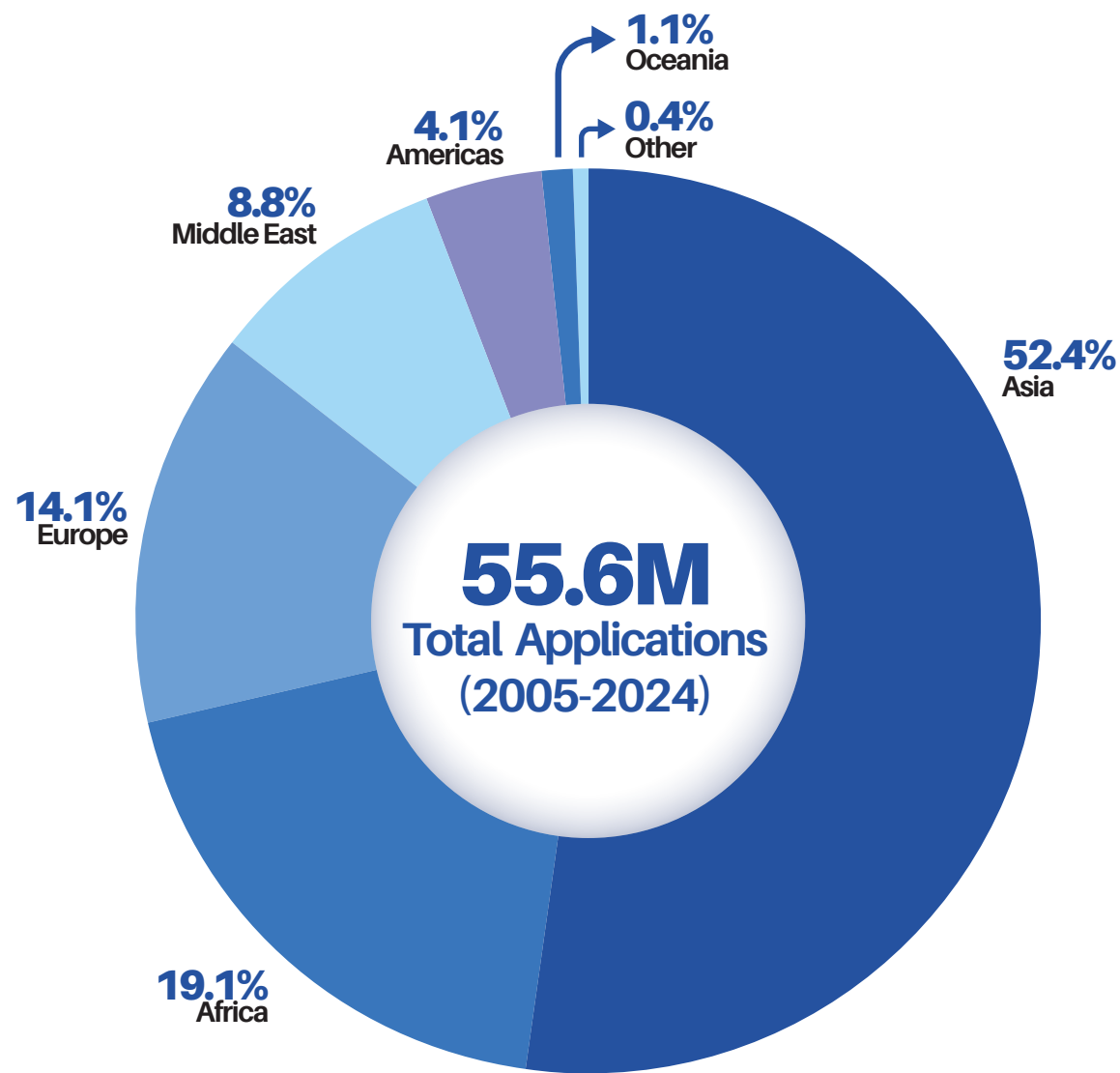
Annual UK visa applications between 2005 and 2024 show a long-term upward trend, with a few notable disruptions. Applications hovered around 2.4–2.9 million annually from 2005 to 2016, before rising steadily to 3.6 million in 2019. The sharp collapse to 1.2 million in 2020 reflects the impact of COVID-19 travel restrictions. Demand rebounded to pre-pandemic levels by 2022, then hit a record 4.1 million in 2023, driven by a backlog of demand and relaxed post-COVID policies. However, the drop to 3.8 million in 2024 suggests the beginning of a slowdown, likely tied to new restrictions on dependants and rising thresholds for work visas.

Quarterly Visa Applications (Q1 2005-Q4 2026)



Quarterly visa applications through mid-2025 remain below the 2023 peak but in line with 2024 levels, totalling an estimated 3.6 million for the year. Forecasts for Q3 2025 to Q4 2026 suggest continued moderation, with annual volumes expected to stay in the 3.3-3.5 million range. The seasonal pattern persists, with applications peaking in Q2 and easing in Q4, but the projections indicate that demand will not return to the record highs of 2023 in the short term.

Total UK Visa Applications by Region (2005-2024)

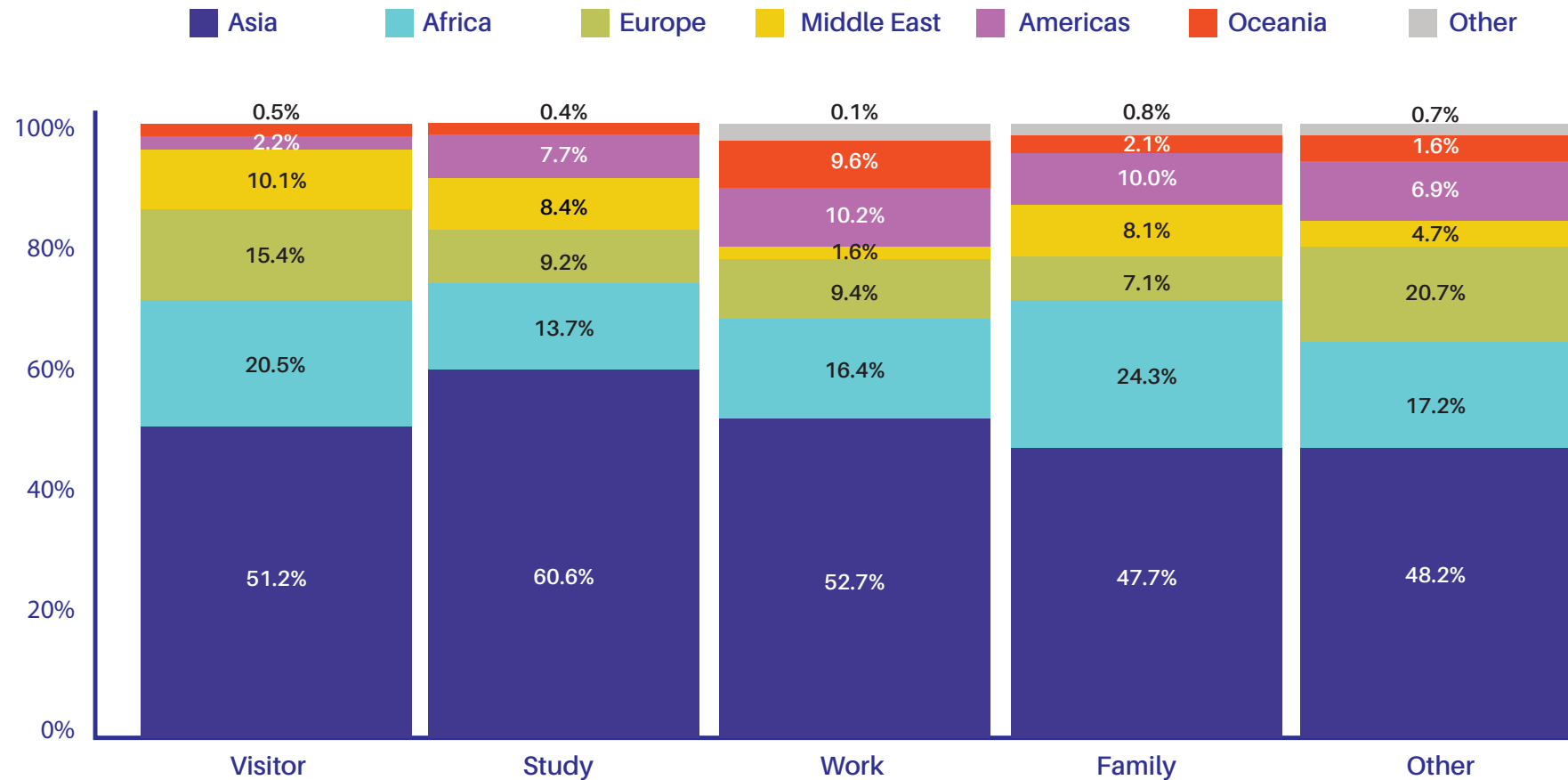


Over 29 million UK visa applications come from Asia, making up more than half of all global requests. This reflects a sustained and growing engagement with the UK across work, study, and tourism.

Africa follows with over 10 million, showing deep, long-standing ties despite lower volumes than Asia. Europe, once dominant, now sits behind both, with 7.8 million applications.

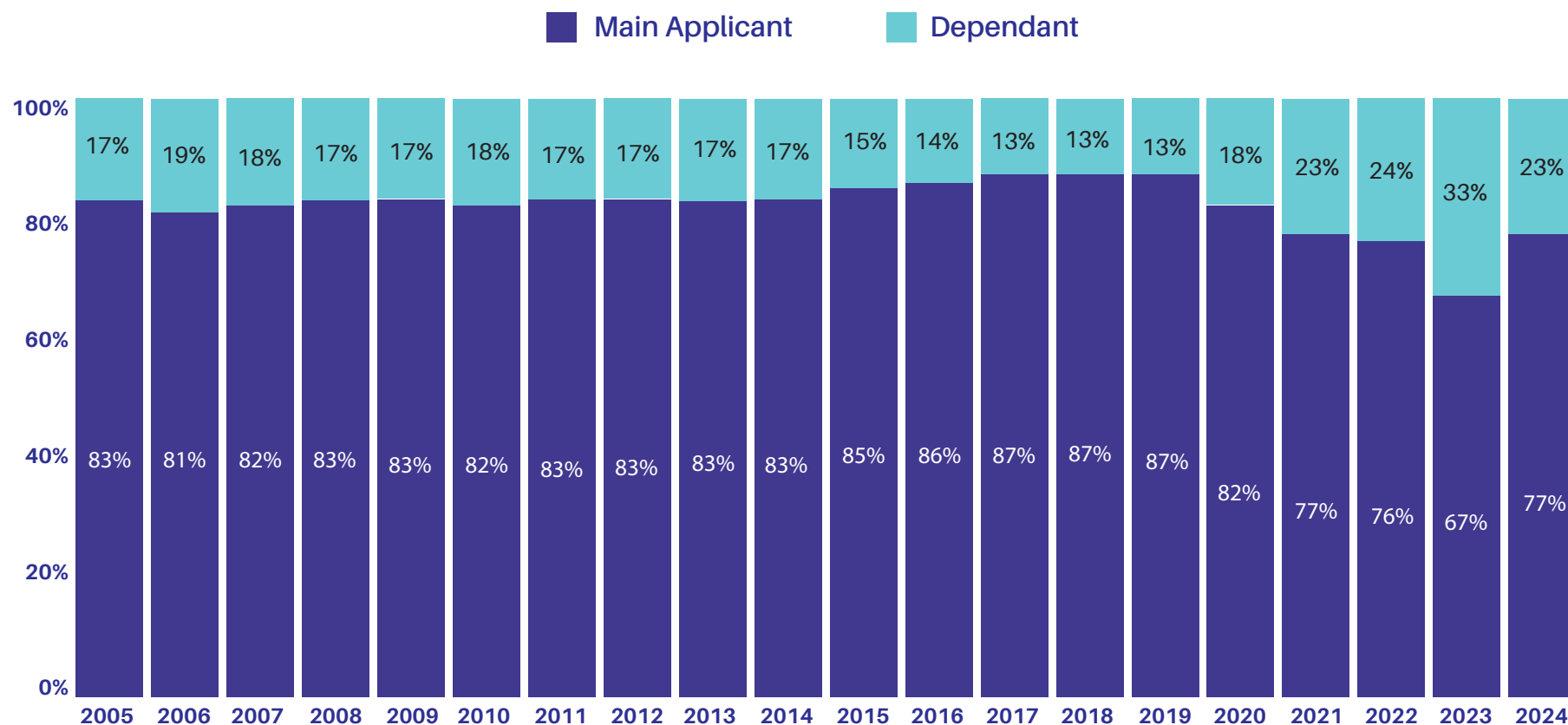
The Middle East, Americas, and Oceania contribute smaller but steady streams, together making up less than 15%. The UK's visa landscape is largely shaped by Asian and African nationals.

Cumulative Visa Applications Category by Region (2005-2024)



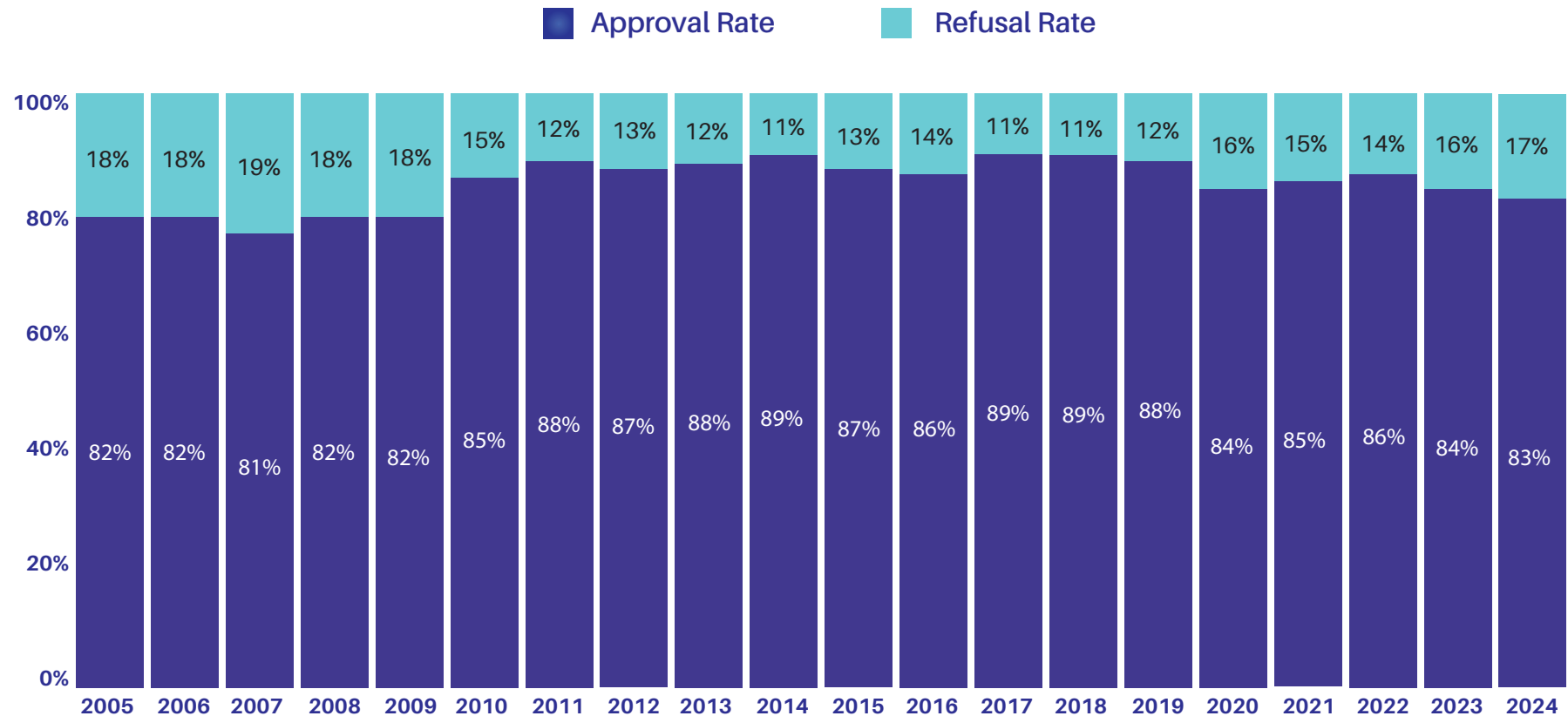
In 20 years, Asia accounted for the largest share of UK visa applications across all categories—most notably 61% of study and 53% of work visas. Africa followed with strong shares in family (24%) and work (16%) routes. Europe played a bigger role in Other visas, while the Middle East and Americas had smaller but steady contributions.

UK Visa Applications by Applicant Type (2005-2024)



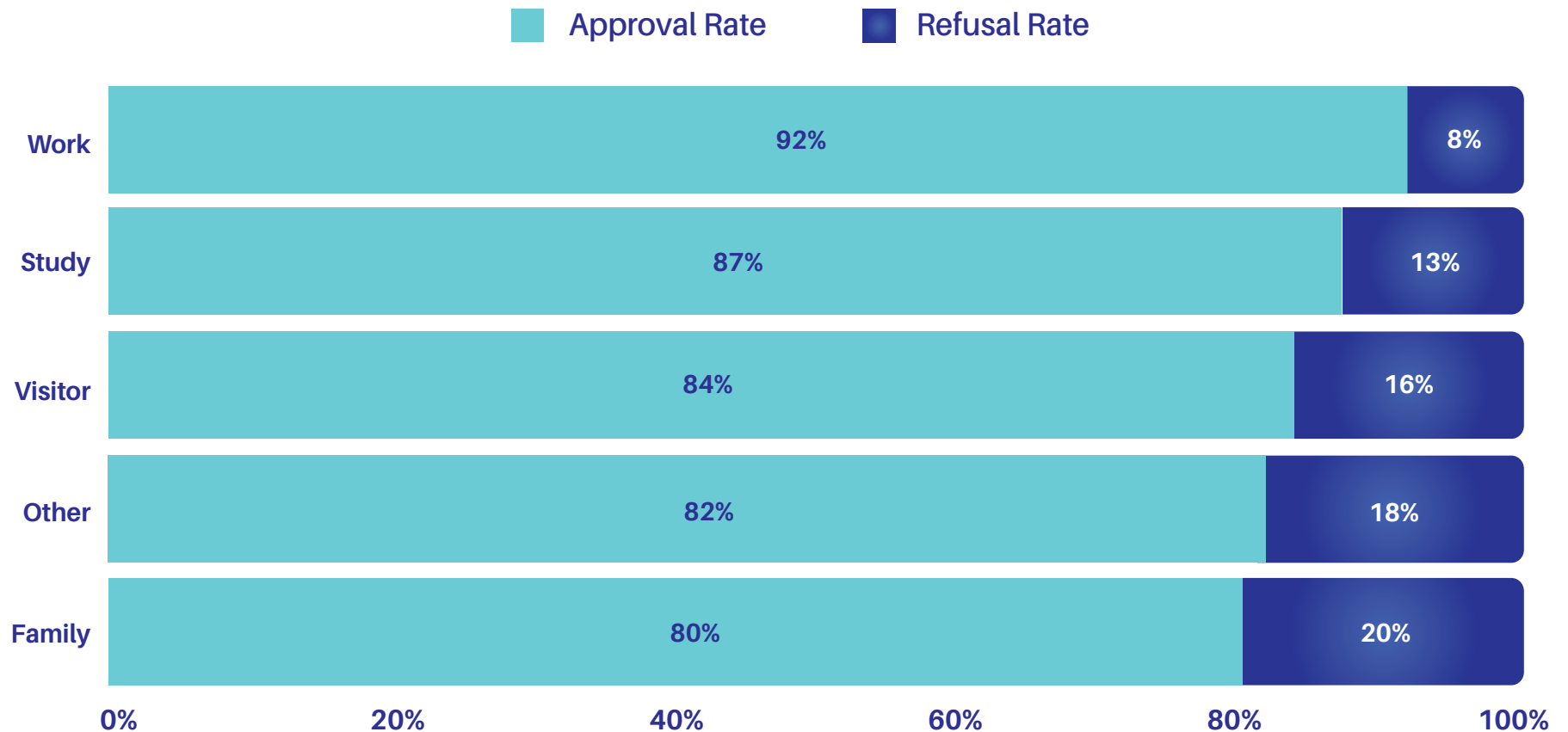
Between 2005 and 2019, dependants consistently made up around 13–19% of all visa applicants, with main applicants accounting for the rest. This balance shifted sharply after 2020, peaking in 2023 when dependants reached 33% of total applications—driven largely by the surge in family and dependant visas tied to work and study routes. By 2024, that share dropped to 23%, reflecting the impact of new restrictions on who can bring dependants, especially care workers and most postgraduate students.

Approval and Refusal Rates for All Visa Categories (2005-2024)



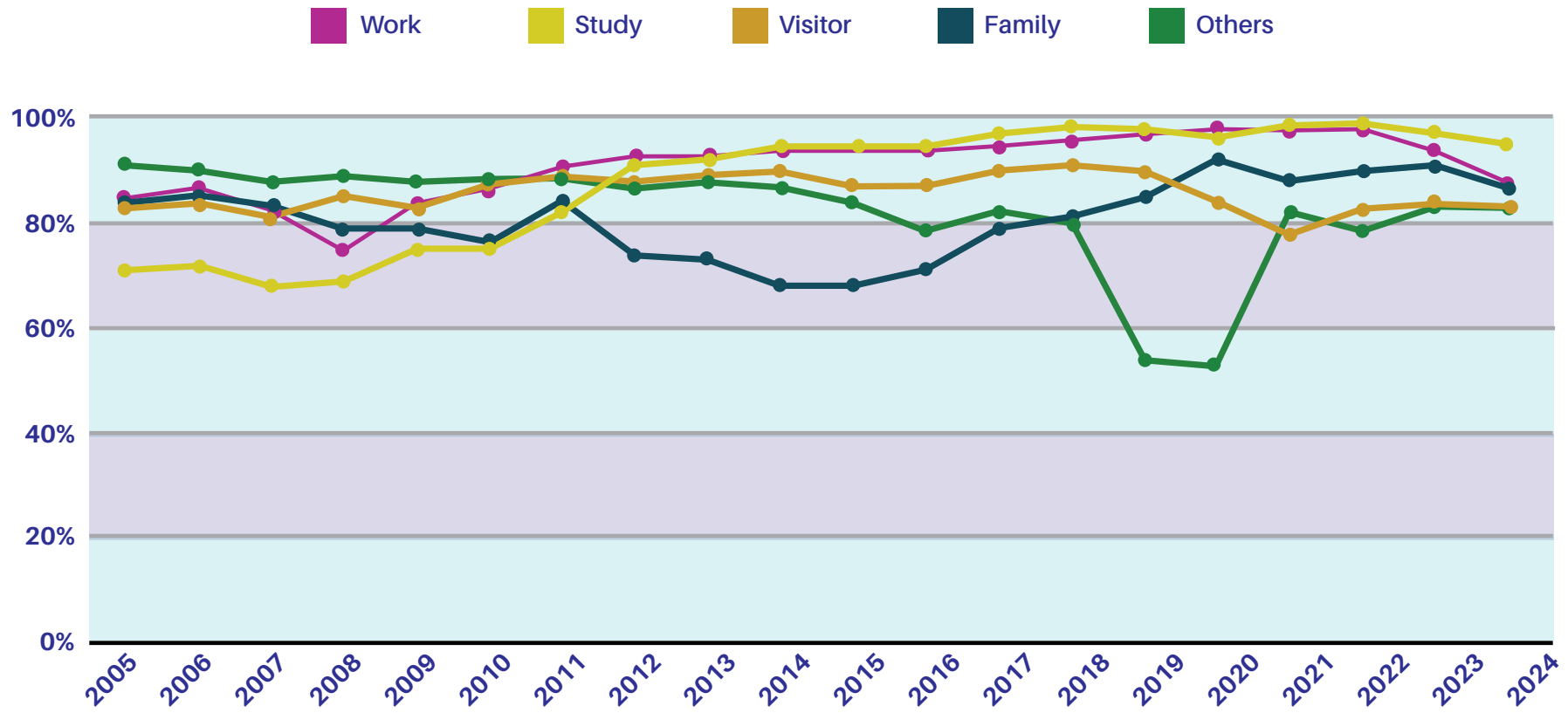
UK visa approval rates mostly stayed high, starting at 82% and peaking at 89% in 2014, 2017, and 2018. The trend remained stable until 2019, after which there was a gradual drop, with approvals falling to 83% by 2024. Refusal rates moved in the opposite direction, dropping to 11-12% during the peak years but rising again to 17% in 2024. Overall, while approvals have stayed above 80%, recent years show a slight downward shift.

Approval Rates for each Visa Category (2005-2024)



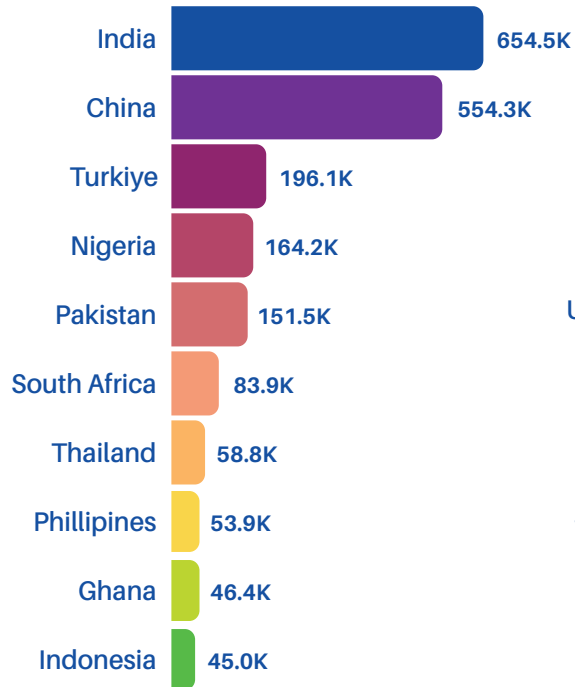
On average, UK Work Visas had the smoothest ride at 92% approval rate between 2005 and 2024, followed by Study Visas at 87%. Visitor Visas came in at 84%, while Other and Family Visas lagged behind at 82% and 80%. Basically, the further an applicant moves from work and study, the bumpier the approval road gets.

Approval Rates for each Visa Category (2005-2024)

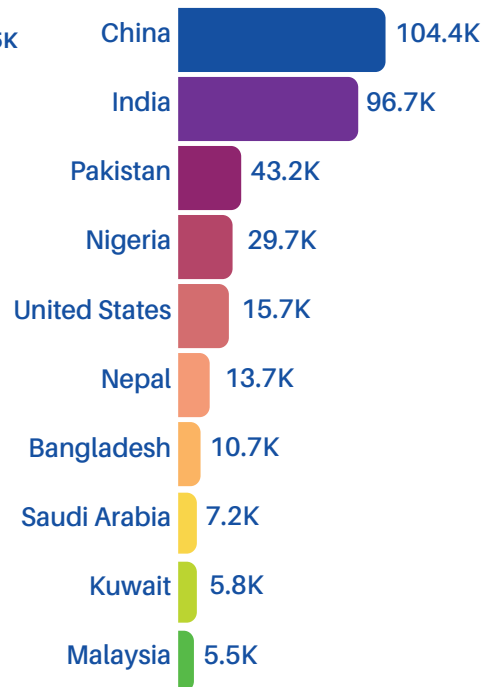


Top Countries by Visa Category in 2024

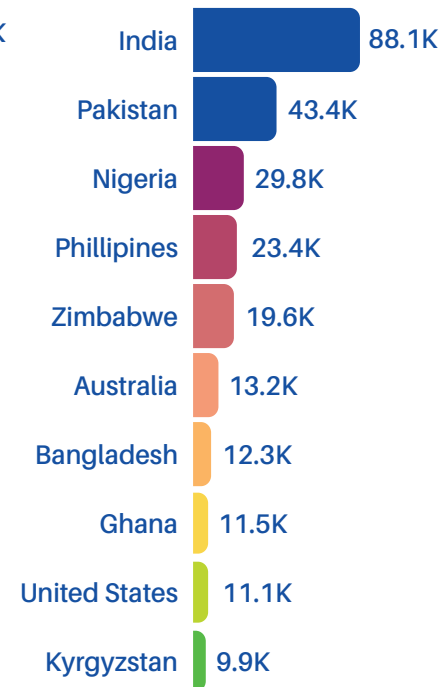
Visitor Visa



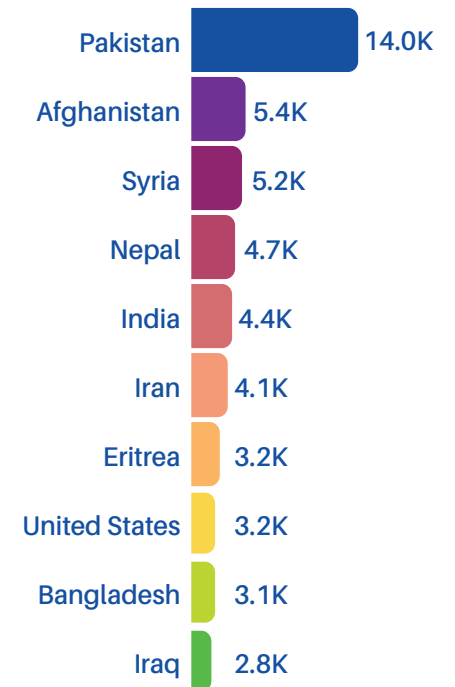
Study Visa



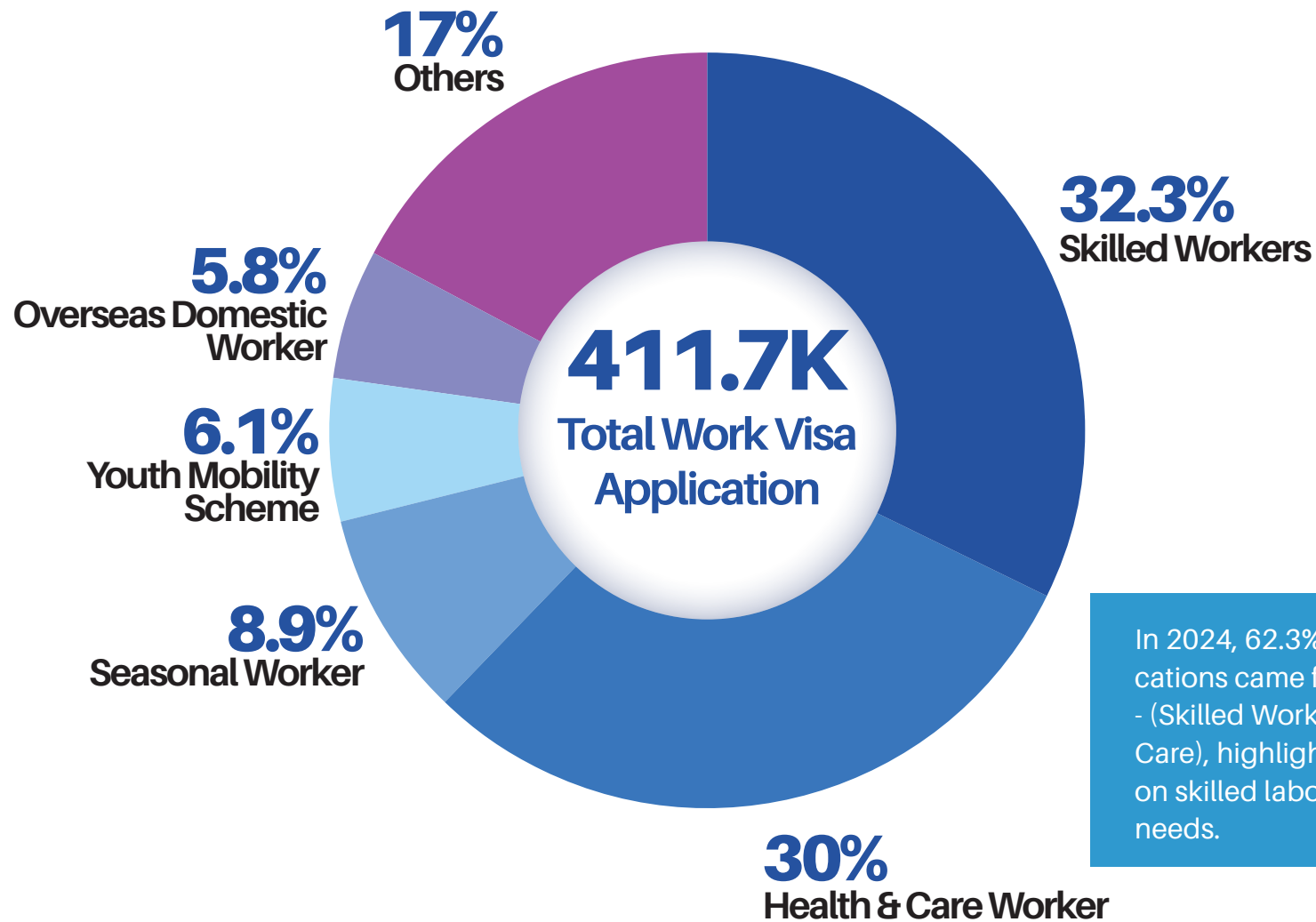
Work Visa



Family Visa

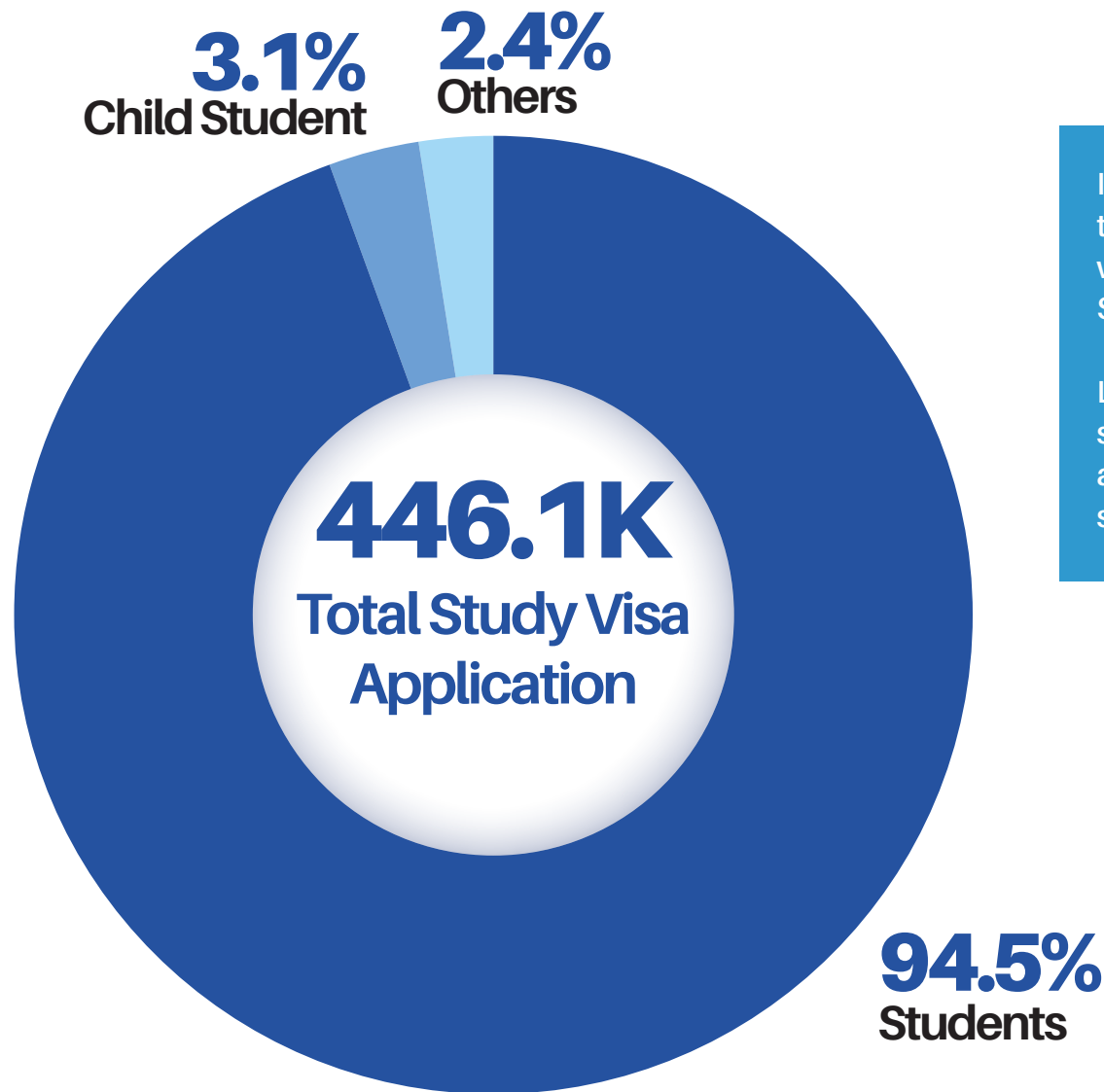


Work Visa Applications in 2024 by Visa Sub-Group



In 2024, 62.3% of Work Visa applications came from just two routes - (Skilled Worker and Health and Care), highlighting the UK's focus on skilled labour and healthcare needs.

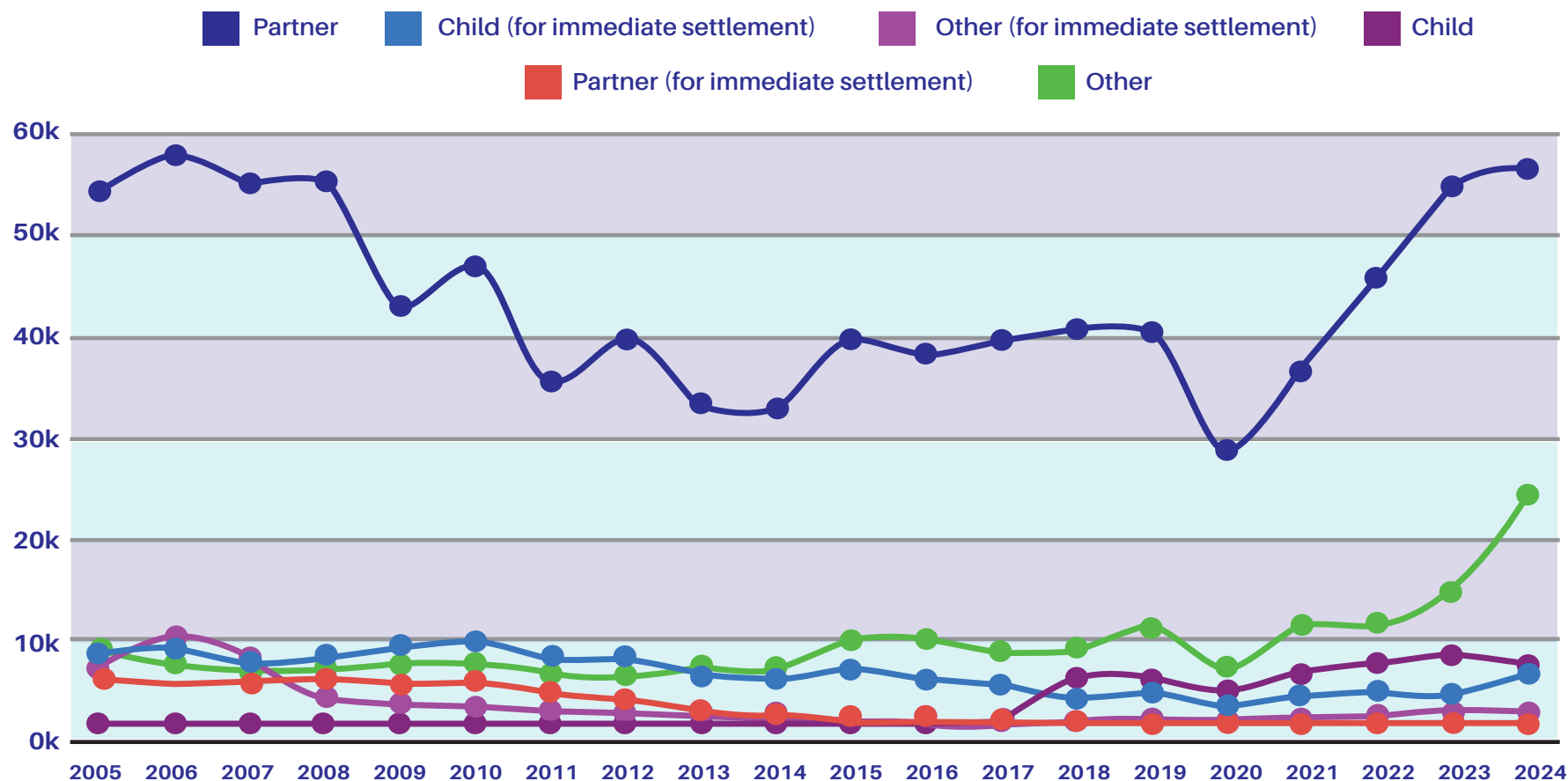
Study Visa Applications in 2024 by Visa Sub-Group



In 2024, 94.5% of all Study Visa applications were for the main Student route, while Child Student and Short-term Study made up just over 5% combined.

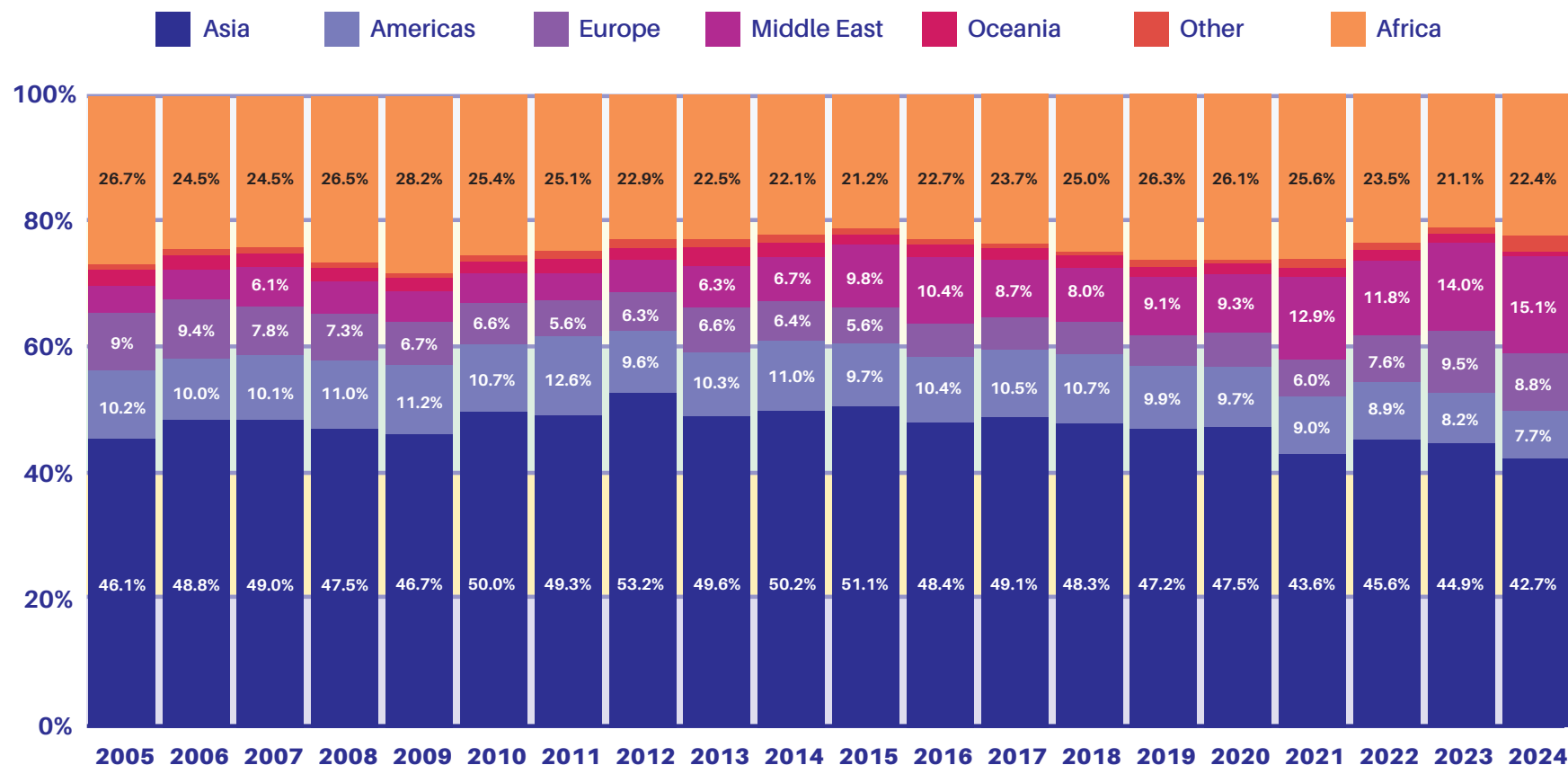
Legacy routes like Tier 4 and other specialist categories recorded almost no activity, showing a near-total shift to the streamlined Student Visa pathway.

Family Visa Applications by Sub-Group (2005-2024)



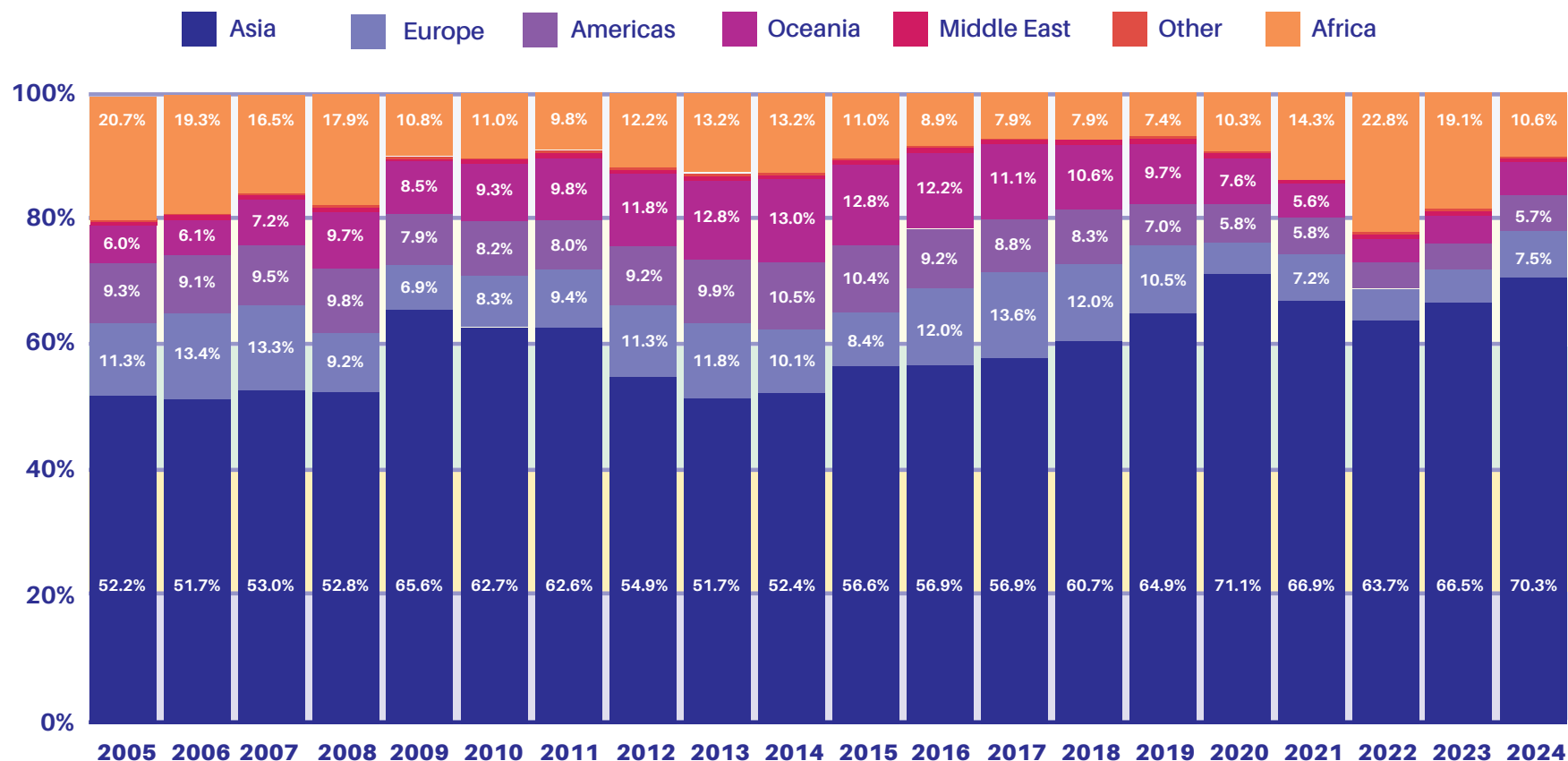
In 2024, Partner Visas remained the dominant family route to the UK, making up 60.8% of all family related applications. Other rose sharply to 23.2k (~25% of all Family Visa applications in the year), its highest share in two decades, possibly reflecting broader eligibility or humanitarian routes. Child applications made up 6.9%, while immediate settlement routes—once more common—collectively accounted for less than 7% of the total.

Work Visa Applications by Region (2005-2024)



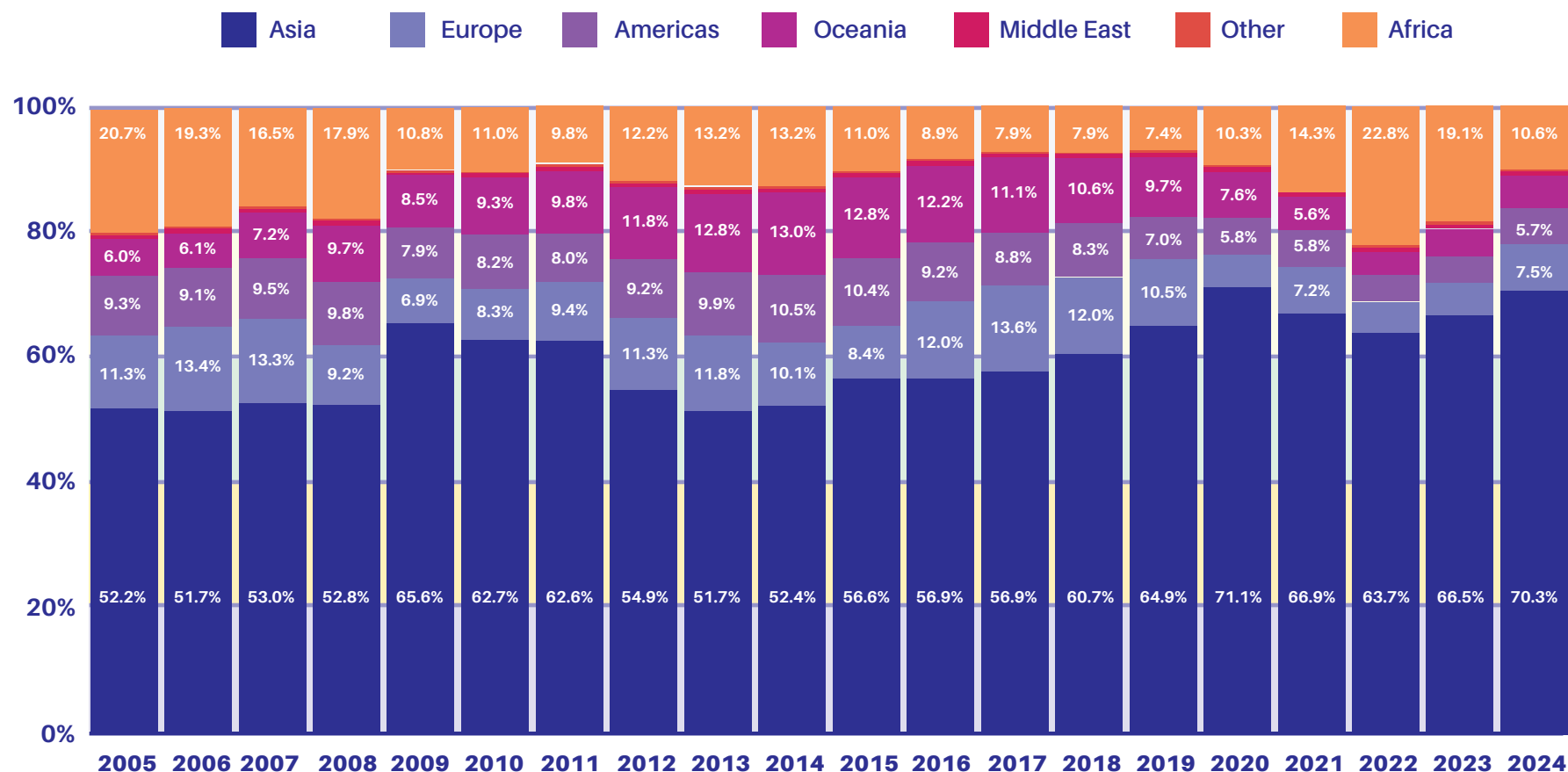
From 2005 to 2024, the majority of UK Work Visa applications came from Asia, consistently above 50% in most years. Africa showed a declining trend until 2015 but rebounded strongly, peaking at 32.9% in 2023. Europe's share dropped sharply after 2006, then temporarily spiked during the Brexit transition. Applications from the Americas, Oceania, and the Middle East remained minor throughout, each staying below 15%.

UK Study Visa Applications by Region (2005-2024)



Asia dominated UK Study Visa applications throughout the period, consistently holding over 50% and peaking at 71.1% in 2020. However, that peak came during the COVID-19 pandemic, when total application volumes dropped, making Asia's share appear larger even as actual numbers fell. Africa's share dipped through the 2010s but rose again in 2022, while Europe and other regions remained low and stable.

UK Family Visa Applications by Region (2005-2024)



Asia consistently led Family Visa applications, maintaining over 40% throughout the period, though its share gradually declined from 50% in 2010 to 42.7% in 2024. Africa followed closely, fluctuating around 25%, while the Americas held a steady 9–12%. Notably, the Middle East's share more than tripled from 4.2% in 2005 to 15.1% by 2024, showing a sharp upward trend.

AFRICA - Key Figures



10.6M

Total applications in 20 years (2005-2024)

531.8K

Average yearly applications

19.3%

Average yearly share of global applications

7.78M

Total visa approvals in 20 years (2005-2024)

3.2K

Eritrea's Family Visa applications in 2024 (highest in Africa)

29.7K

Nigeria's Study Visa applications in Africa (highest in Africa)

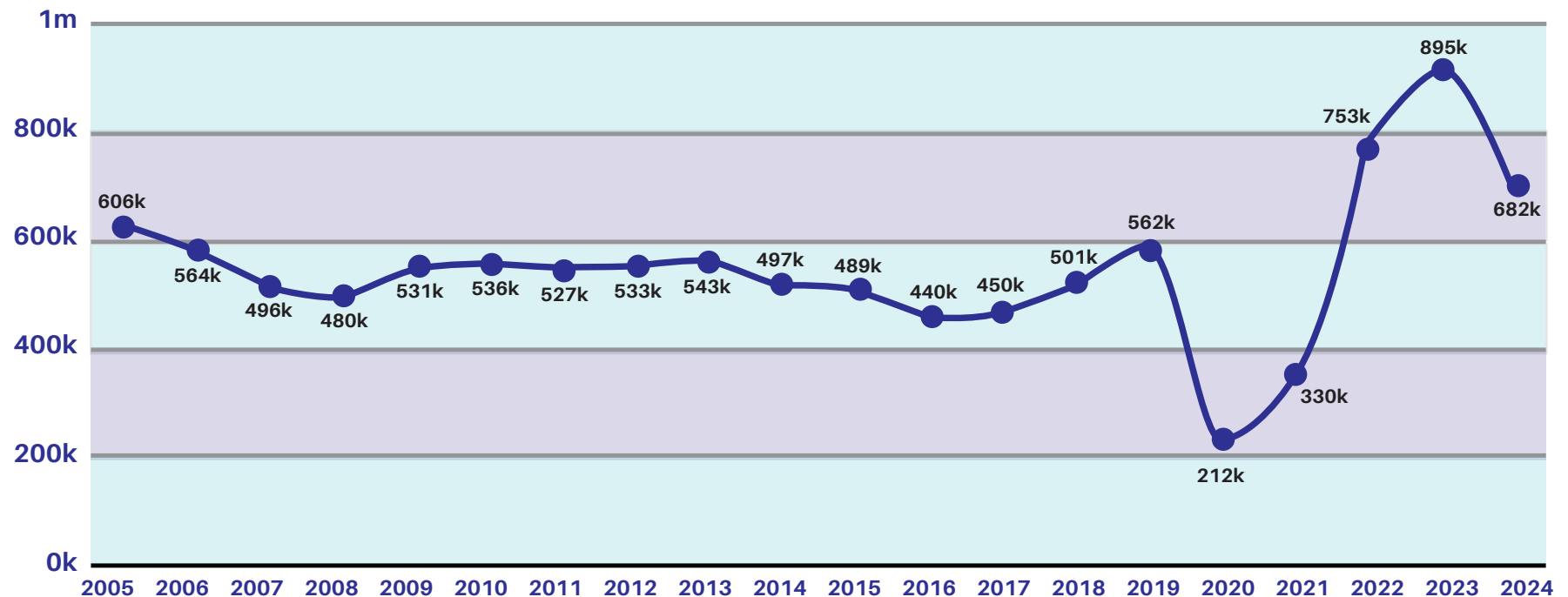
29.8K

Nigeria's Work Visa applications in 2024 (highest in Africa)

84.7%

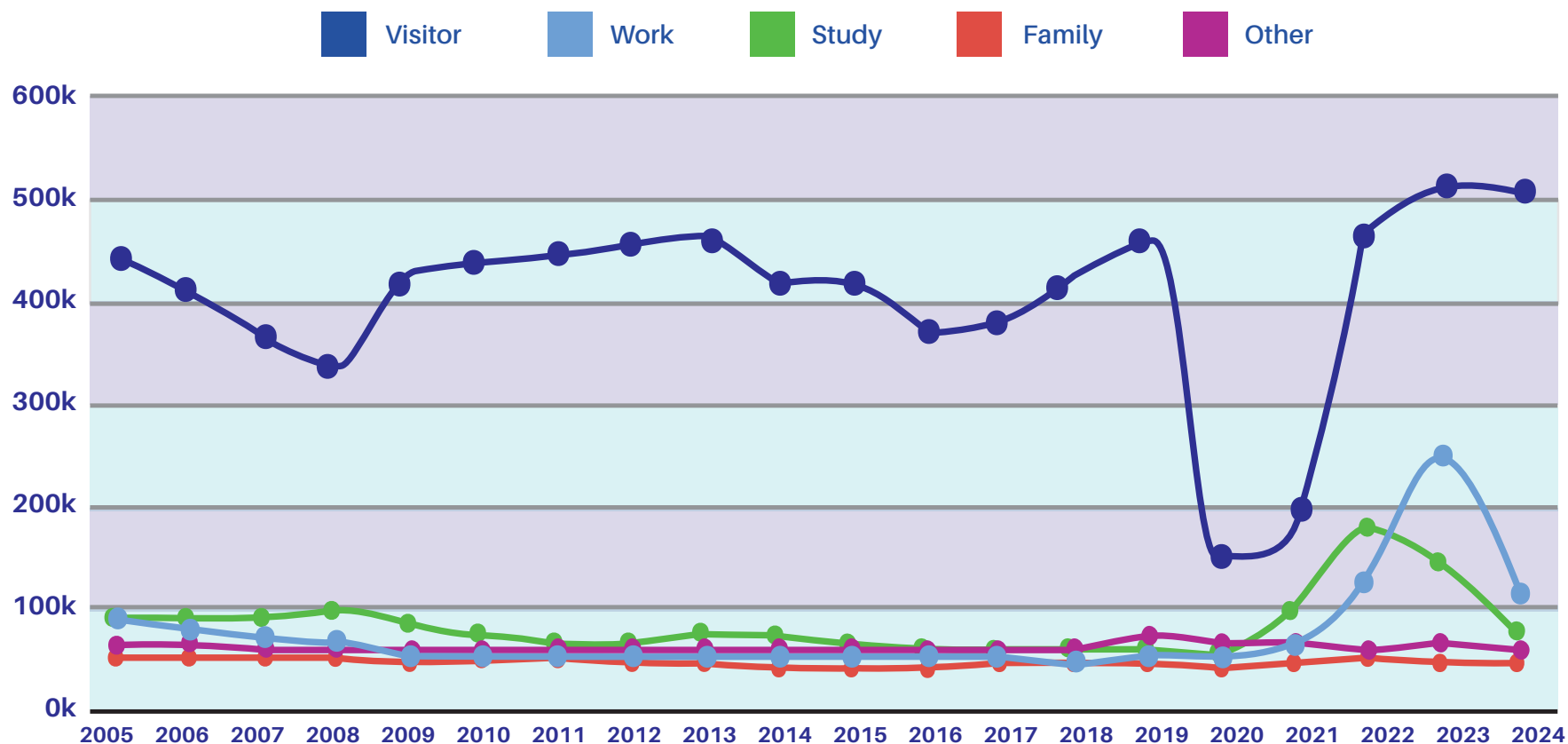
Average approval rate for Work Visa applications (highest amongst visa categories)

Africa: UK Visa Applications



Visa applications from Africa remained relatively stable between 2005 and 2019, fluctuating between 440,000 and 600,000 annually. A sharp dip followed in 2020, with applications falling to 219,500 due to the COVID-19 pandemic. Post-pandemic recovery was rapid, with applications more than doubling in 2022 to 752,600, and peaking in 2023 at 895,200—the highest on record for the continent. This surge was largely driven by growth in study and work routes, especially in sectors like health and care. However, 2024 saw a drop to 682,200, likely reflecting the impact of new restrictions on dependants and care worker eligibility, which heavily affected African applicants.

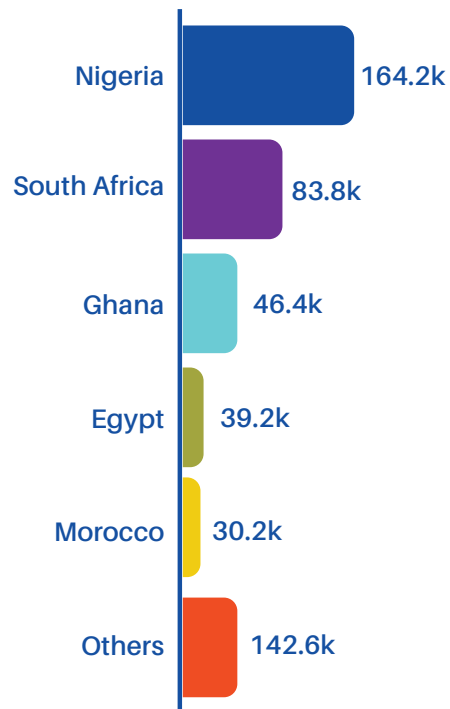
Africa: Applications by Visa Category



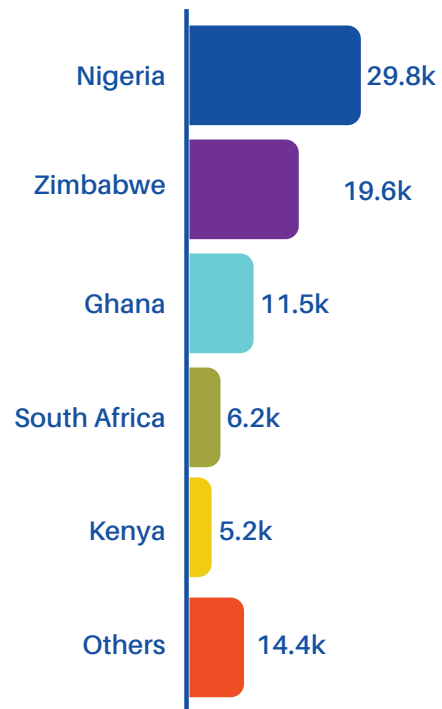
Most UK visa applications from Africa were for Visitor Visas, consistently the largest category and peaking at over 500,000 in 2023. Study Visa applications saw sharp post-pandemic growth, rising from 26,800 in 2020 to 146,100 in 2022, but dropping to 47,300 in 2024 following restrictions on student dependants. Work Visa applications surged in 2023 to 218,700, largely due to demand in care and health sectors, before falling steeply to 84,000 in 2024 after new income and sponsorship rules. These trends show how UK policy shifts have directly shaped the scale and type of migration from Africa.

Top African Countries by Visa Category (2024)

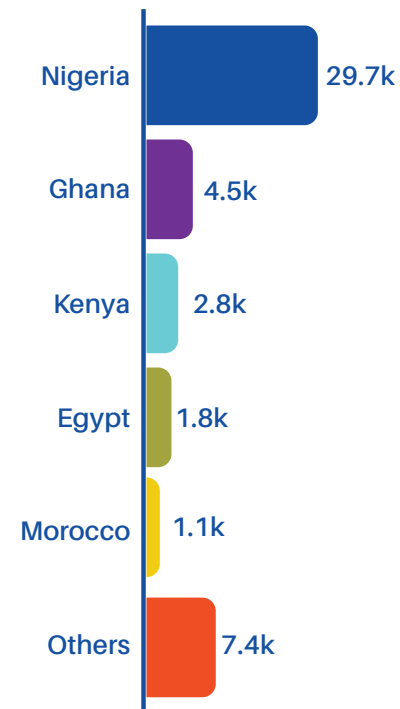
Visitor Visa



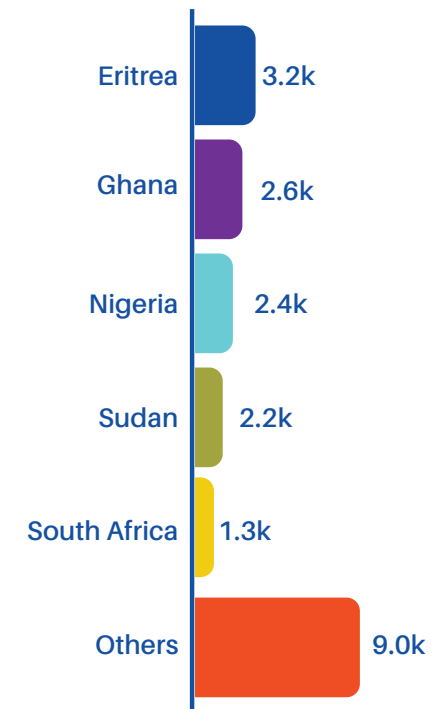
Work Visa



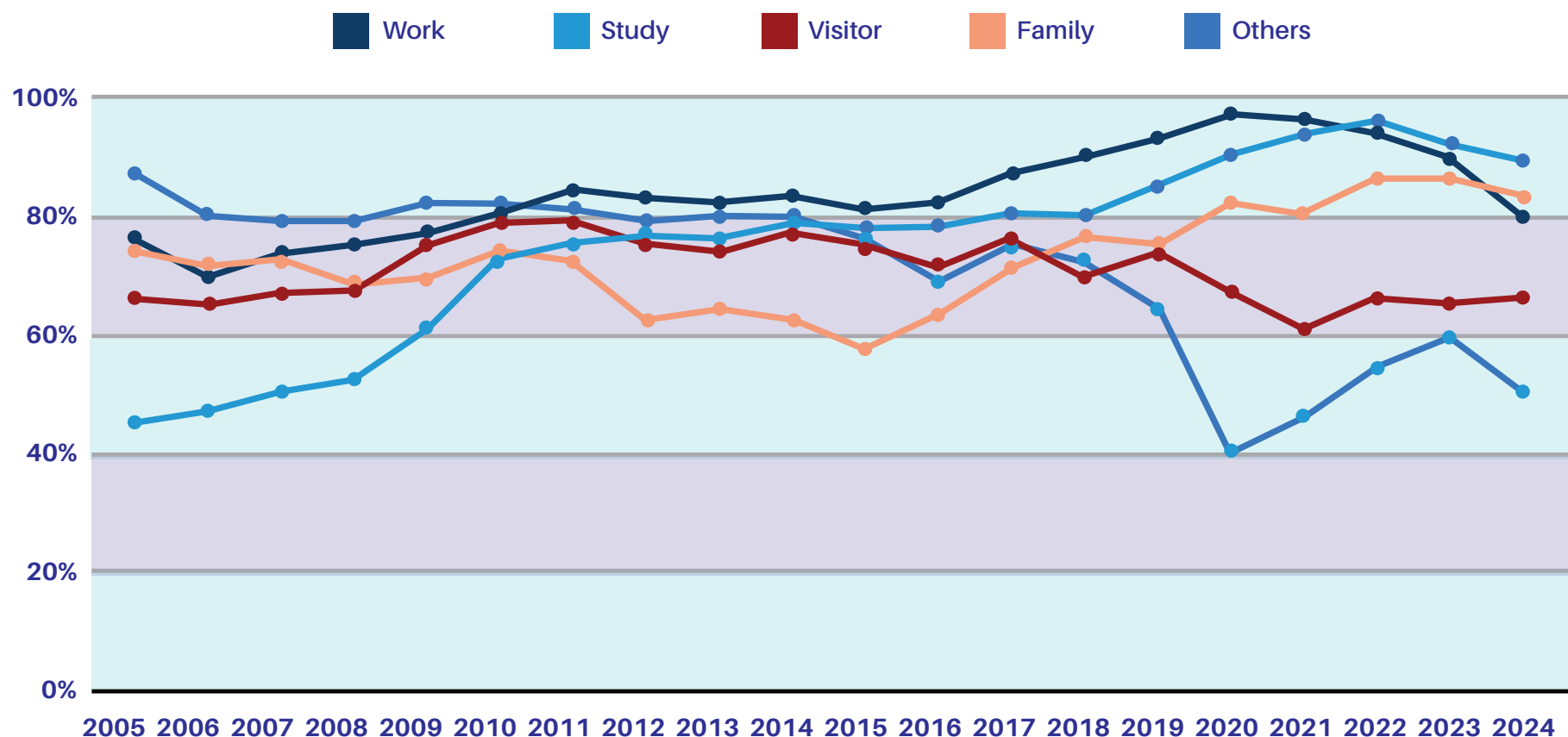
Study Visa



Family Visa

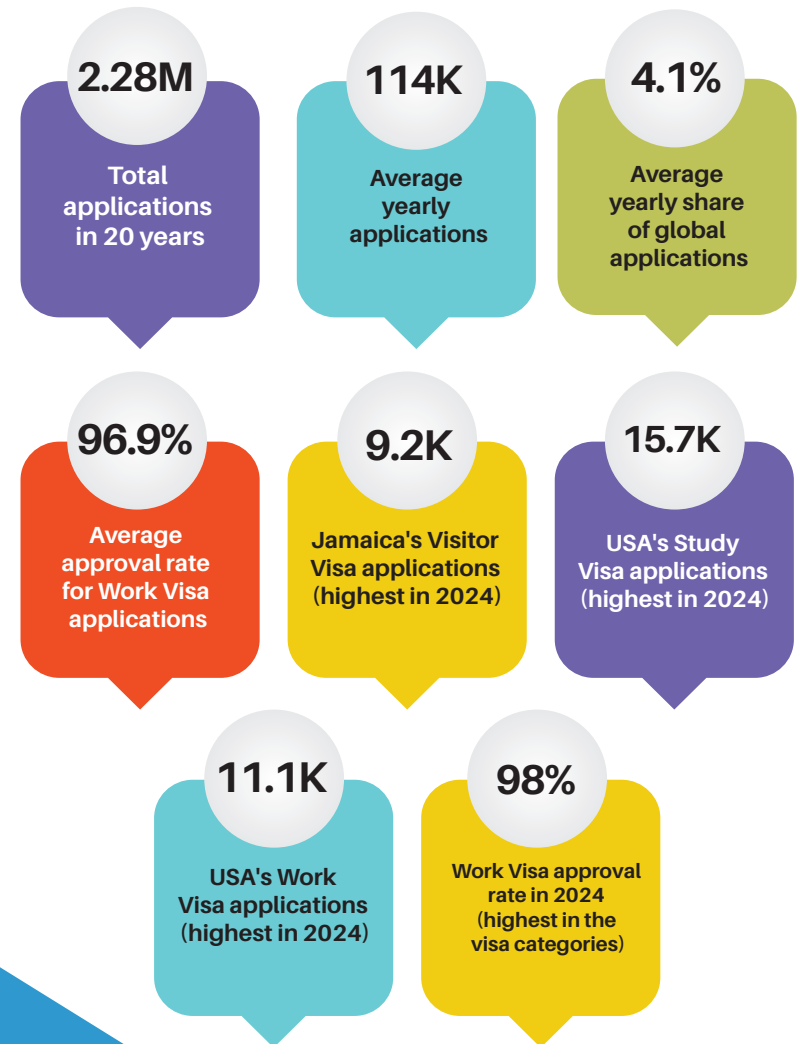


Africa: Approval Rates by Visa Category (2005-2024)

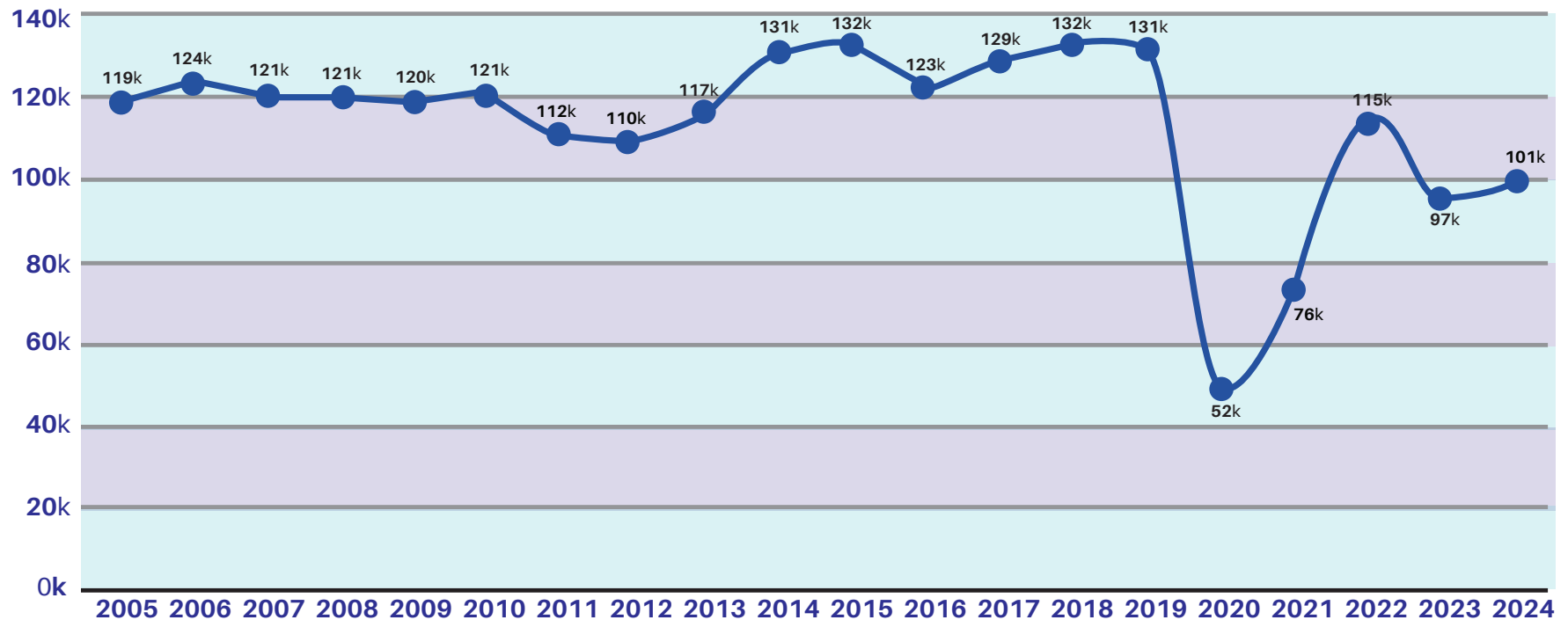


Work and Study Visa approvals for African applicants have improved significantly. Study Visa rose from just 46% in 2005 to 97% by 2022, and Work Visa hit 98% in 2020. Visitor Visas, however, remained shaky, hovering in the 60s and 70s with no clear upward trend. Family Visas dipped below 60% in 2015 but climbed back to the 80s by 2024. Other Visa approvals dropped sharply, falling from over 80% in the 2000s to just 41% in 2020 and struggling to recover since. In short, while work and study routes are now far more accessible, the rest remain challenging.

AMERICAS - Key Figures

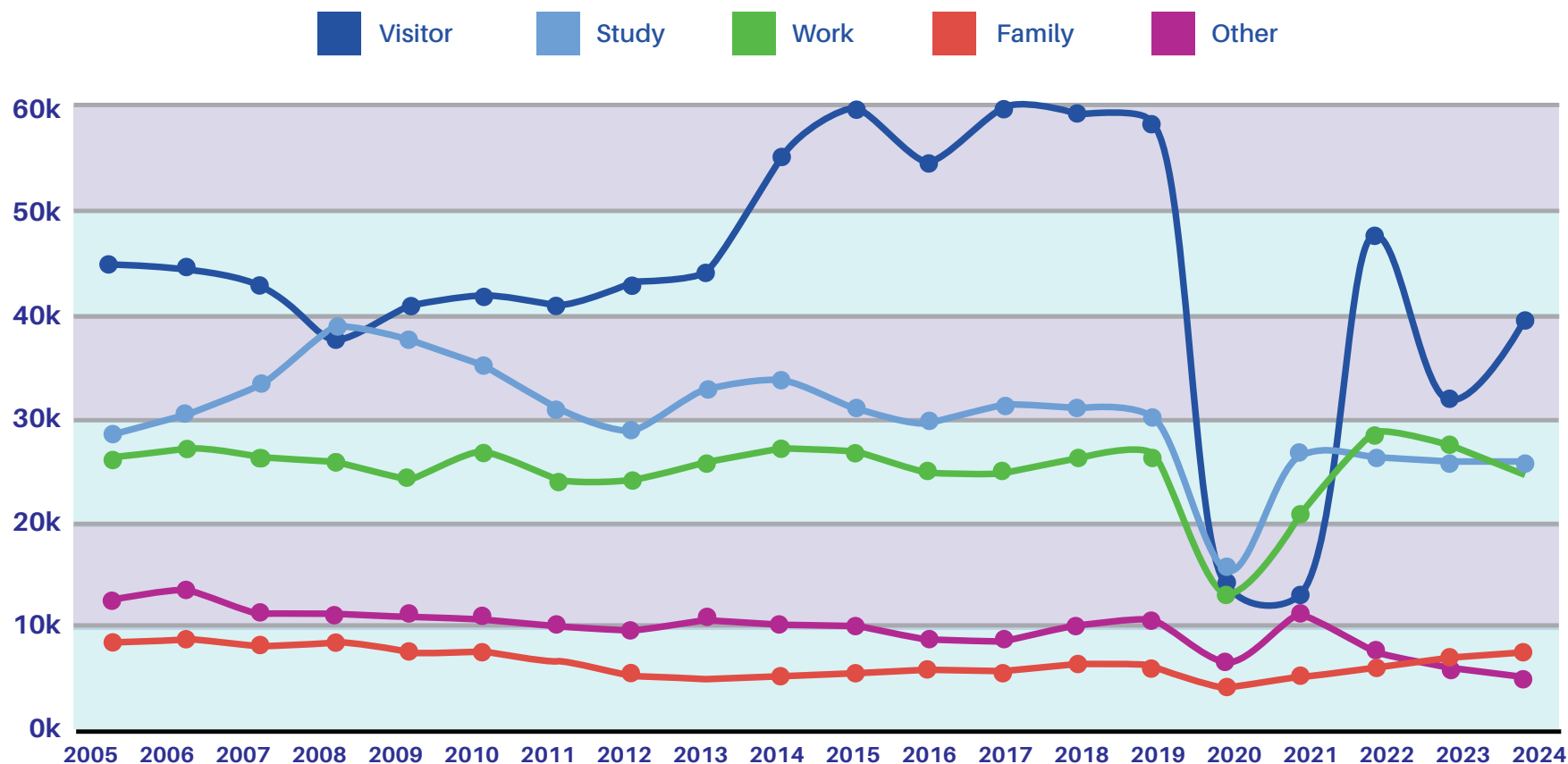


Americas: UK Visa Applications (2005-2024)



UK Visa applications from the Americas were stable from 2005 to 2019, averaging around 125,000 per year, with little year-on-year change. The sharp 60% drop to 52,200 in 2020 reflected the global travel shutdown during COVID. While applications bounced back by 120% to 114,700 in 2022, they haven't exceeded pre-pandemic levels. By 2024, applications stood at 100,900, still 20% below the 2019 total. Unlike Asia or Africa, migration from the Americas hasn't been driven by large structural shifts like Brexit or dependant visa bans, suggesting demand is steady but less reactive to UK policy changes.

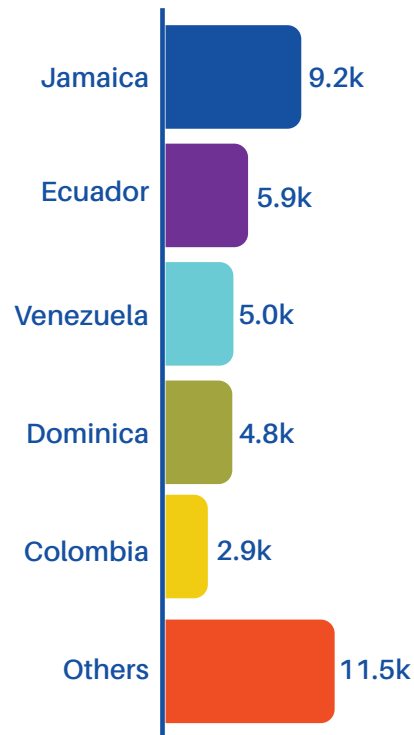
Americas: UK Visa Applications by Visa Category (2005-2024)



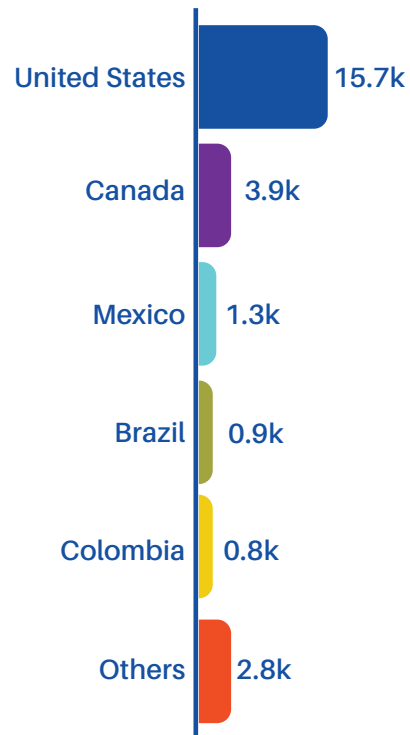
For the Americas, Visitor visas were the biggest driver, climbing above 59k in the mid-2010s before sliding back, then taking a steep pandemic hit and recovering unevenly. Study visas peaked in 2008 near 39k, but since then have steadily shrunk to the mid-20k range. Work visas stayed steady at around 25k through most years, with a post-pandemic rebound that briefly pushed them above earlier levels. Family visas have gradually declined from over 8k in 2005 to around 7k in 2024, while other visas have steadily thinned out, falling from double digits to under 5k. Visitor visas once dominated, but the balance between visitor, study, and work streams has narrowed in recent years.

Top Countries in the Americas by Visa Category in 2024

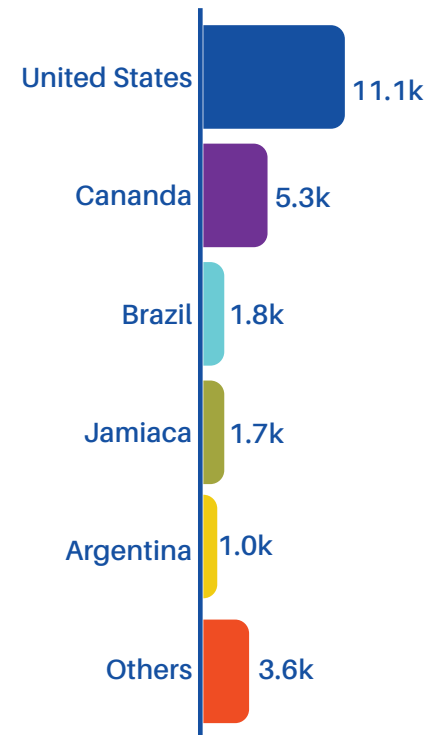
Visitor Visa



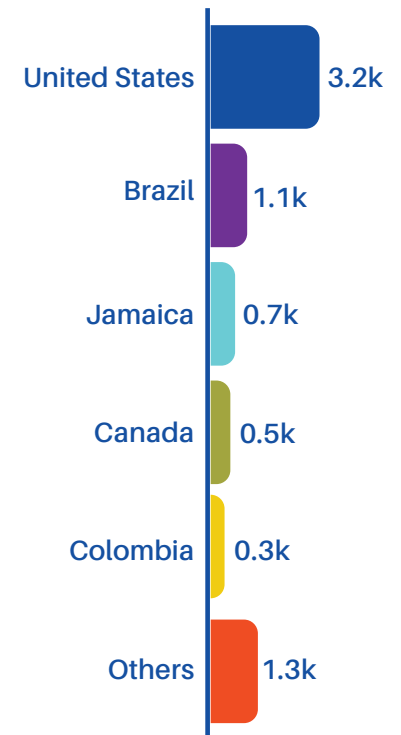
Study Visa



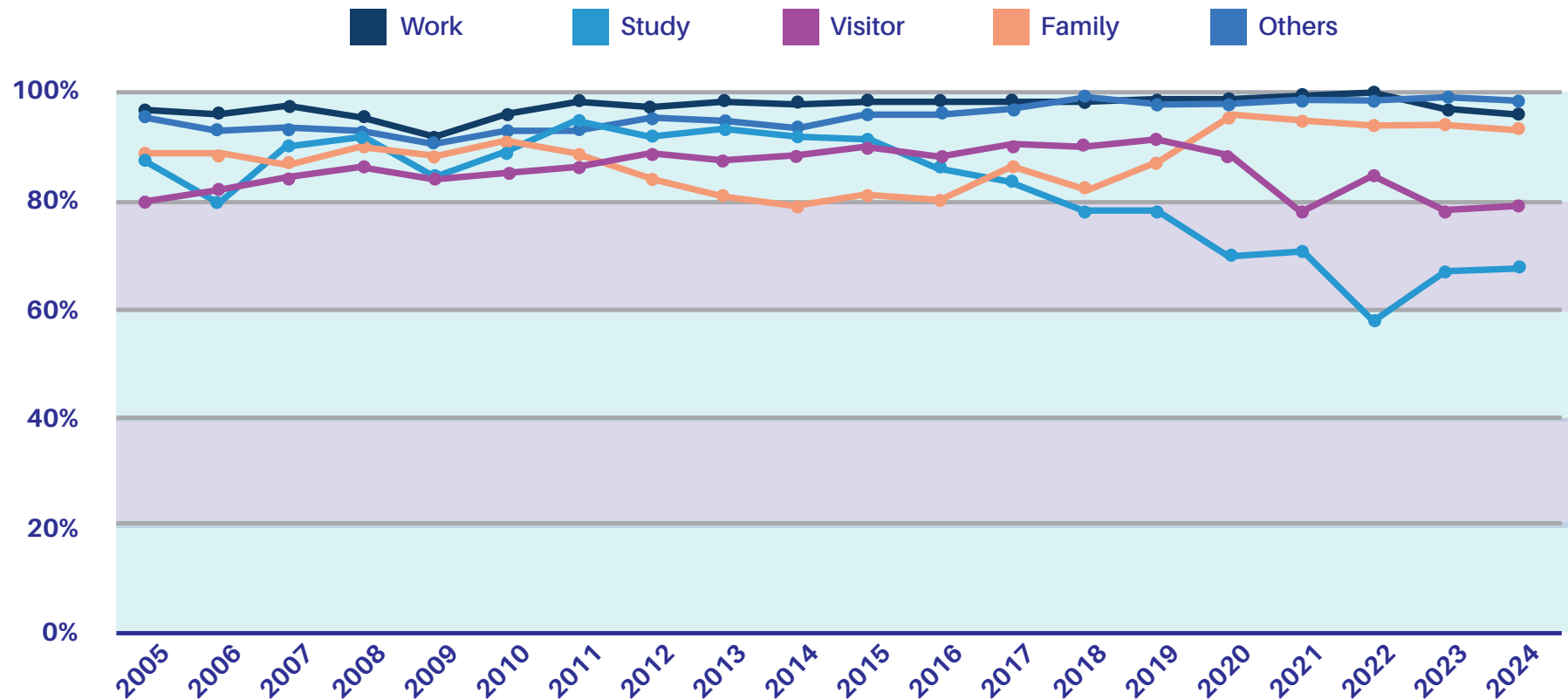
Work Visa



Family Visa



Americas: Approval Rates for each Visa Category (2005-2024)



For applicants from the Americas, Work and Study Visas were the most reliable routes, with approval rates staying between 96% and 99% over two decades. Visitor Visa approvals hovered in the 80s but slipped to 78-79% in recent years. Family Visas held fairly steady, mostly in the 80s and 90s. Meanwhile, Other visa types declined sharply, from over 90% in the early years to just 58% in 2022 before a slight rebound. Overall, work and study routes offered the best odds for approval, while others became less predictable.

ASIA - Key Figures



29.2M

Asia's Total applications in 20 years (2005-2024)

1.43M

Average yearly applications from Asia

48.4%

Yearly average share of global applications

25.3M

Asia's Total visa approvals in 20 years (2005-2024)

14K

Pakistan's Family Visa applications in 2024 (highest in the region)

417.6K

Most visa applications recorded (2023)

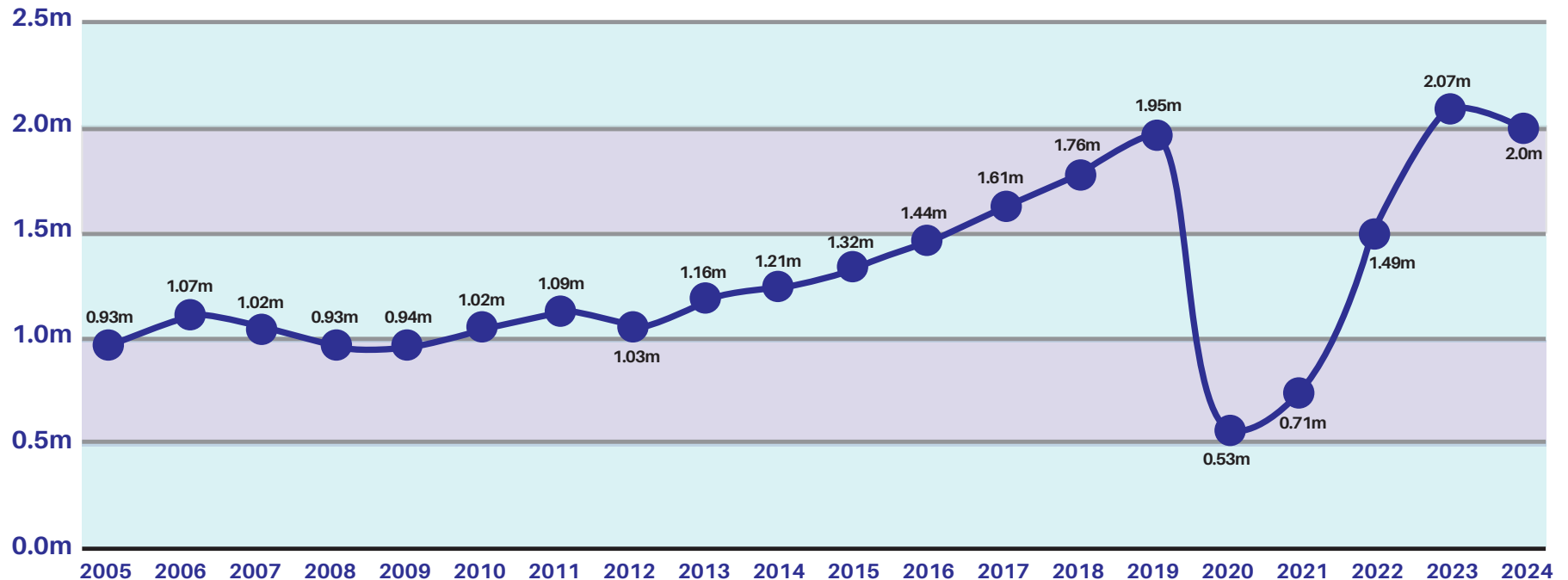
88.1K

India's Work Visa applications in 2024 (highest in Asia)

91.4K

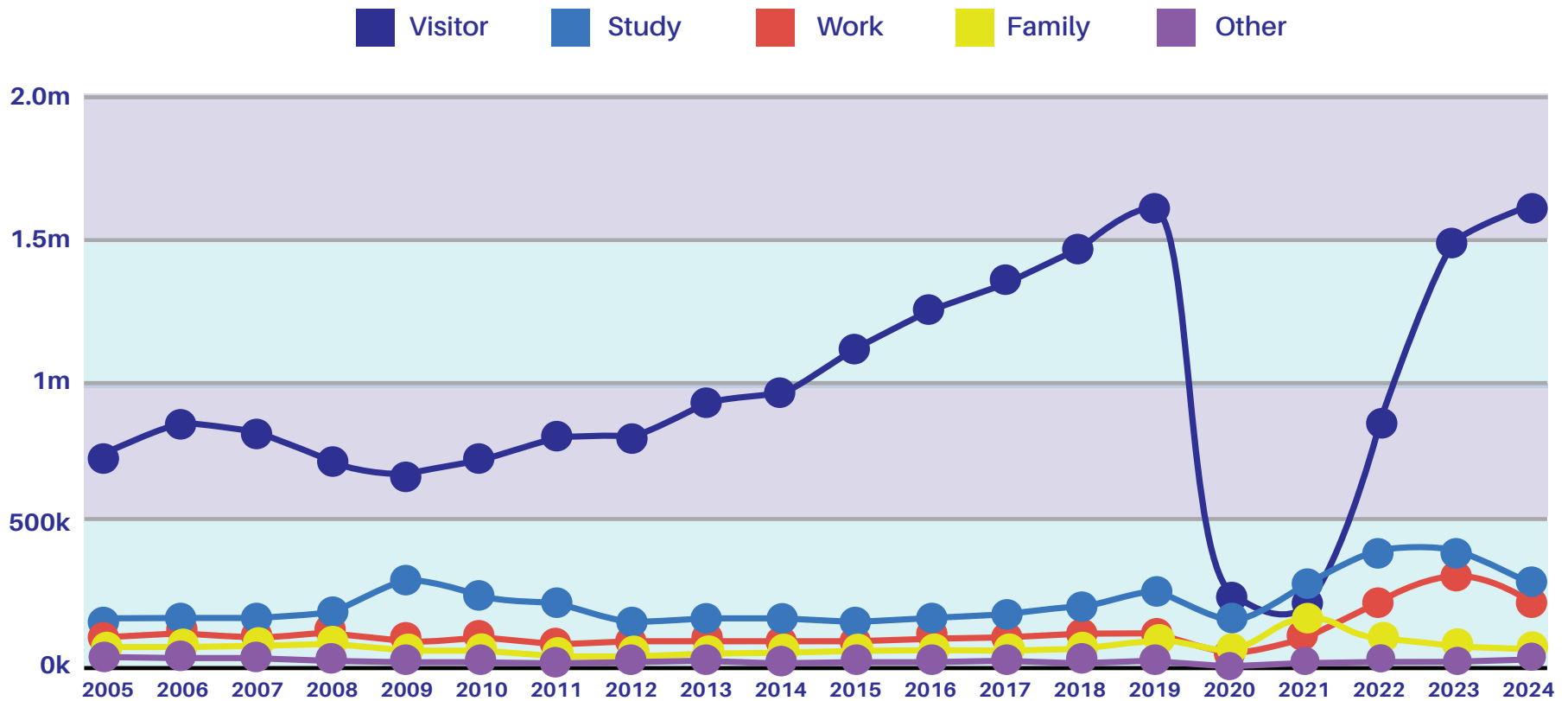
Average Work Visa approval rate (highest of the visa categories)

Asia's UK Visa Applications (2005-2024)



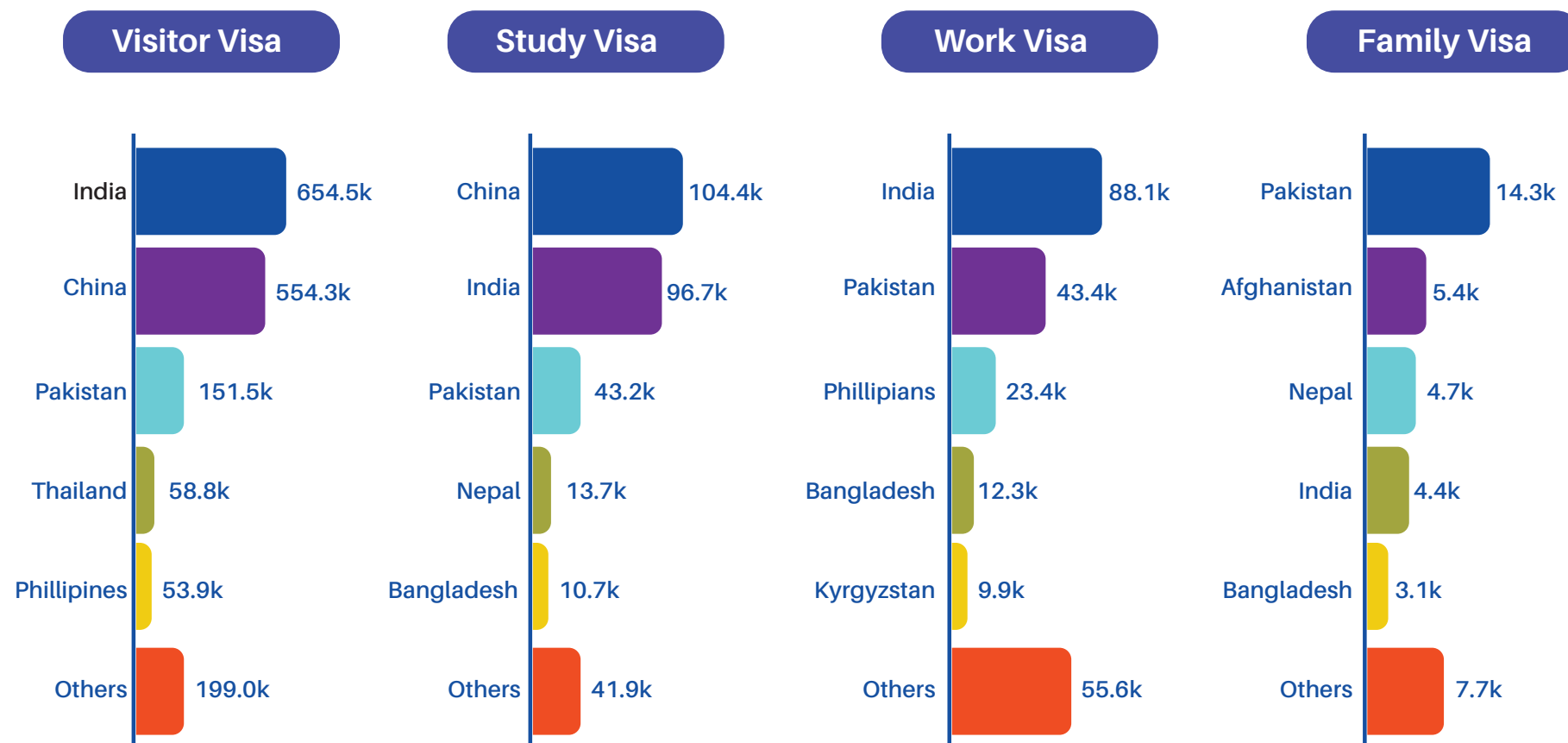
Asian applications have more than doubled in two decades. From fewer than 1 million applications in 2005, Asian demand for UK visas climbed steadily through the 2010s, crossing 1.9 million by 2019. The pandemic years brought a sharp collapse, but recovery was swift, and by 2023 applications hit a record 2.07 million before easing slightly in 2024.

UK Visa Applications by Category (2005-2024)

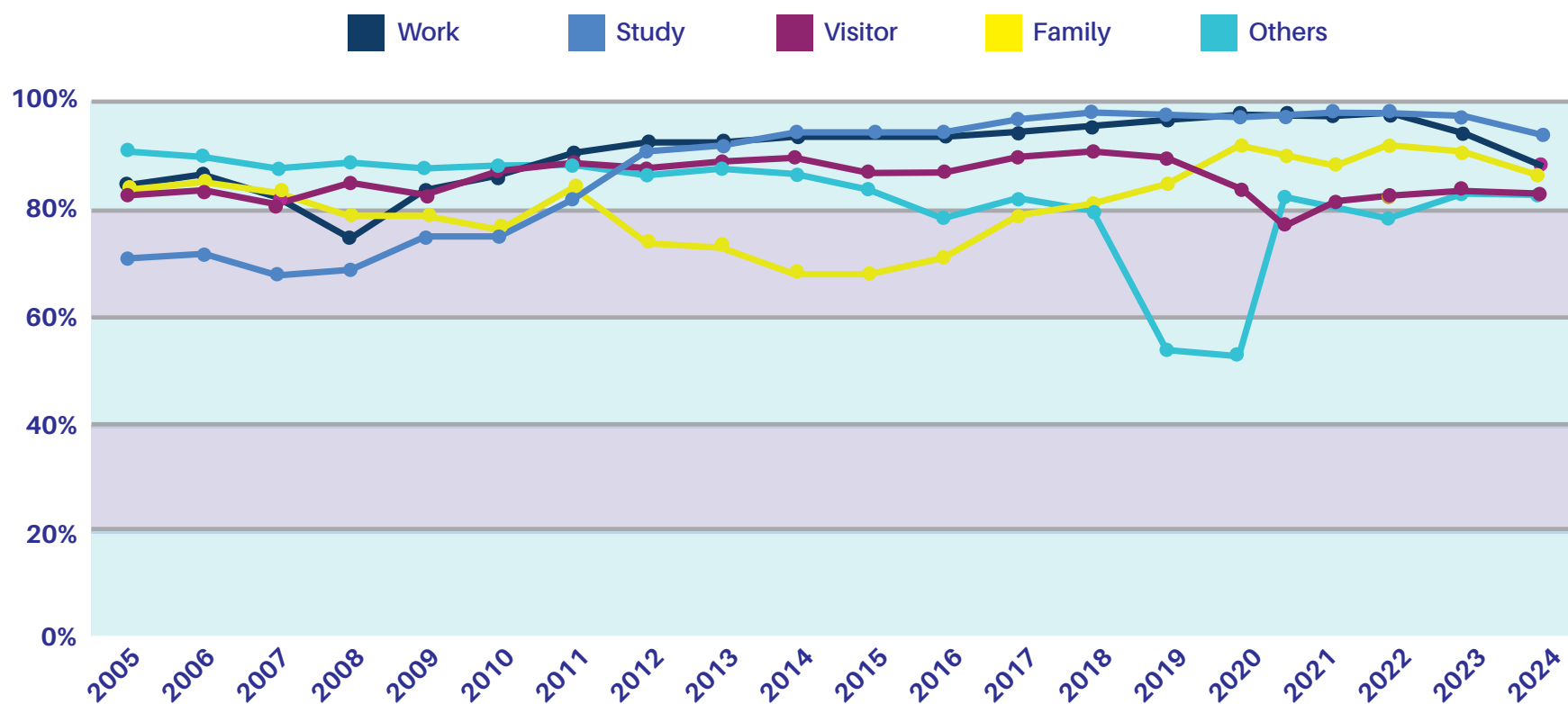


Work Visa applications saw modest growth from 114k in 2005 to around 115k by 2019, with occasional dips like in 2009 (93k) and 2011 (90k). The number dropped sharply to 61k in 2020 due to COVID-19, then bounced back strongly, reaching a peak of 341.7k in 2023—almost triple pre-pandemic levels. This spike reflects new employer demand, the expanded Skilled Worker route, and global shifts in mobility. In 2024, applications dropped to 232.8k, still double typical pre-2020 volumes, showing sustained demand post-COVID.

Top Asian Countries Application by Visa Category in 2024



Asia: Approval Rates for each Visa Category (2005-2024)



Asia showed strong progress in UK visa approvals, especially in work and study routes; study approvals surged from 71% in 2005 to a high of 99% in 2022, and work stayed consistently above 90% from 2011 onward. Visitor Visa approvals held steady around 83% in recent years after fluctuating earlier. Family Visas dipped in the mid-2010s but recovered to over 90% by 2023. Other visa approvals dropped sharply to the 50s in 2019-2020 but bounced back to 83% by 2024.

EUROPE - Key Figures



7.82M

Total applications in 20 years

391.1K

Average yearly applications

14.3%

Average yearly share of global applications

91.7%

Average approval rate for Work Visa applications

2.0K

Türkiye's Family Visa applications in 2024 (highest in Europe)

196.1K

Türkiye's Visitor Visa applications in 2024 (highest in Europe)

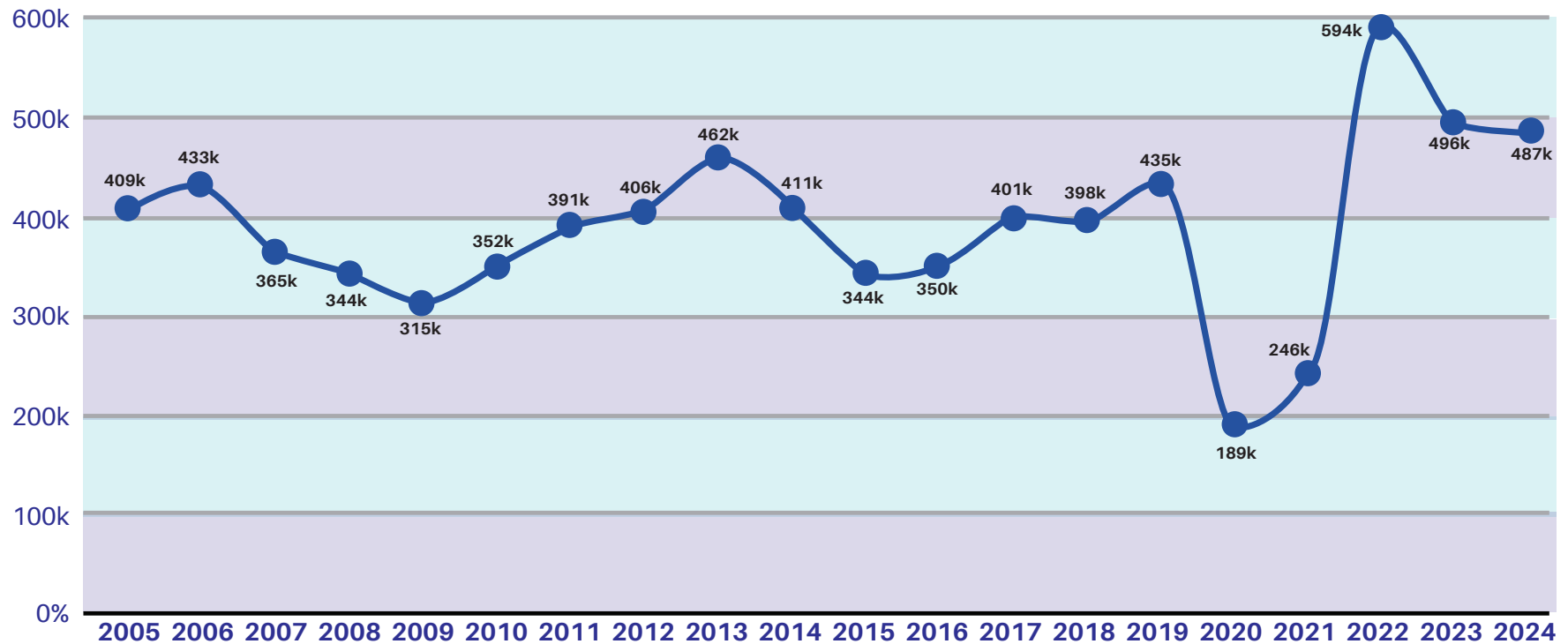
230.3K

Peak Work Visa applications recorded in 2022

98%

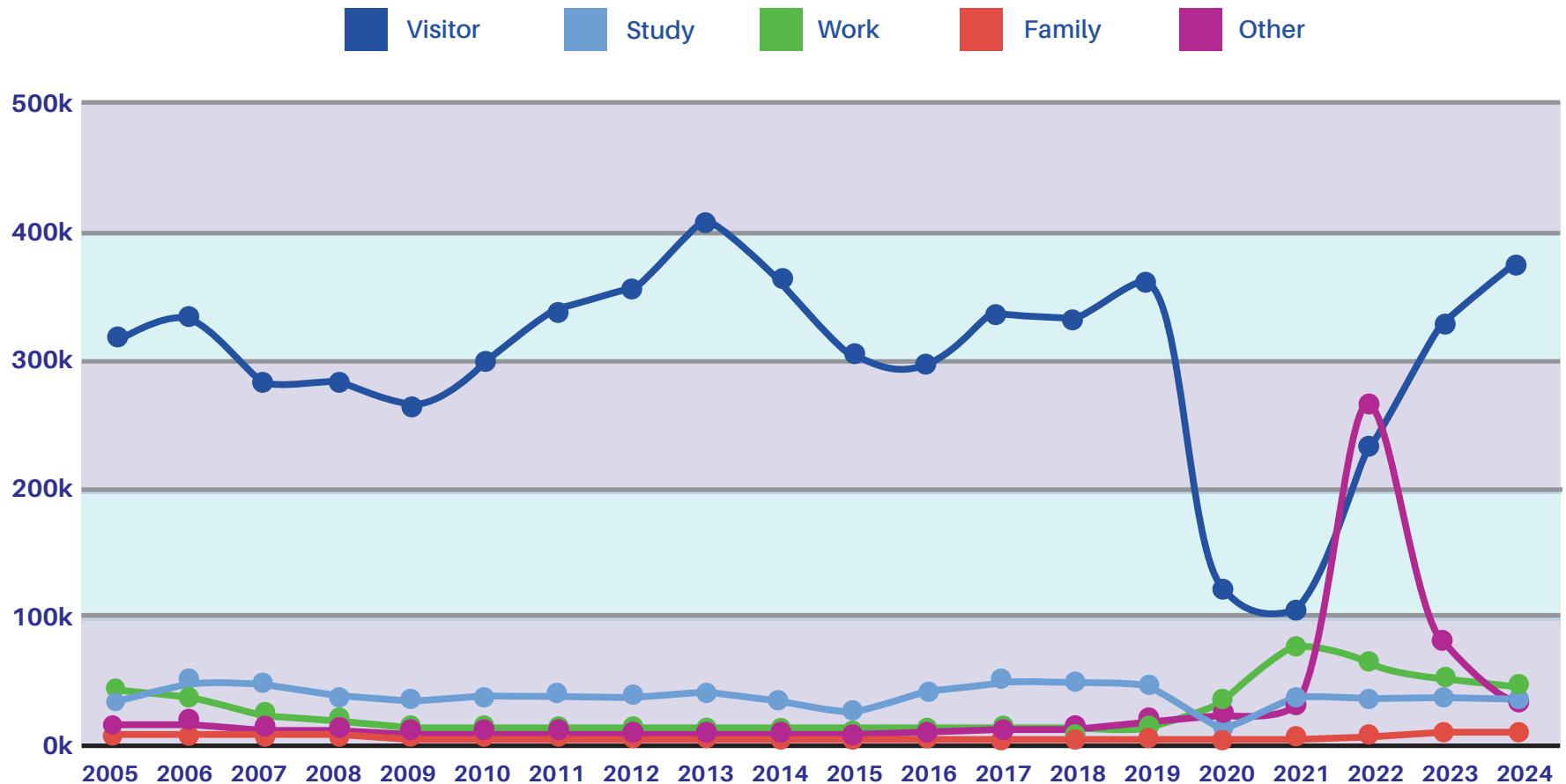
Study Visa approval rate in 2024 (highest among visa categories)

Europe: UK Visa Applications



Visa applications from Europe remained relatively steady between 2005 and 2019, averaging around 400,000 annually, before falling sharply to 189,300 in 2020 due to the pandemic. Post-Brexit, applications surged to a record 593,800 in 2022, as EU nationals adjusted to new visa requirements. Though this spike tapered slightly in 2023 and 2024, totals remained well above pre-Brexit levels, reflecting Europe's transition from free movement to formal visa processes.

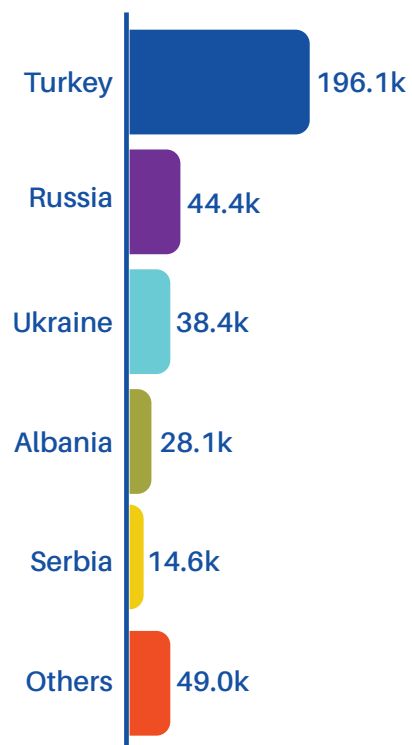
Europe: UK Visa Applications by Visa Category



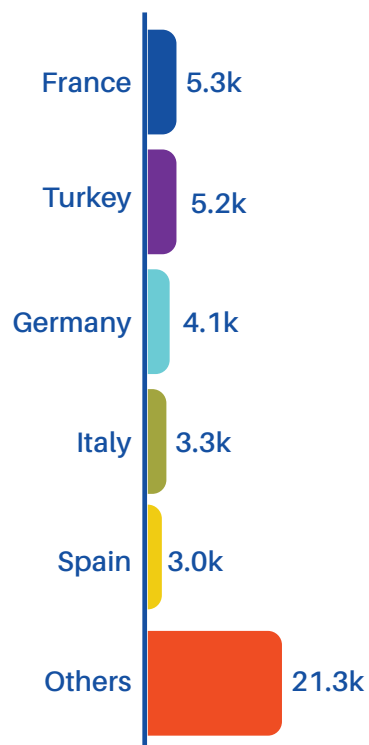
From 2005 to 2024, most UK visa applications from Europe were for visitor visas, rising from 315,600 in 2005 to 370,600 in 2024. Work Visa applications remained low until Brexit, then spiked to 74,200 in 2021 as EU citizens began needing visas. A sharp rise in Other Visas in 2022 (264,000) reflects EU Settlement Scheme related entries. Overall, Brexit shifted European migration from free movement to formal visa routes.

Top European Countries Applications by Visa Category in 2024

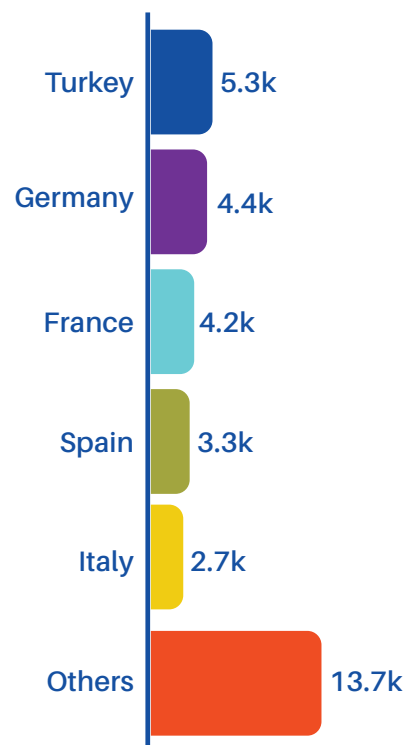
Visitor Visa



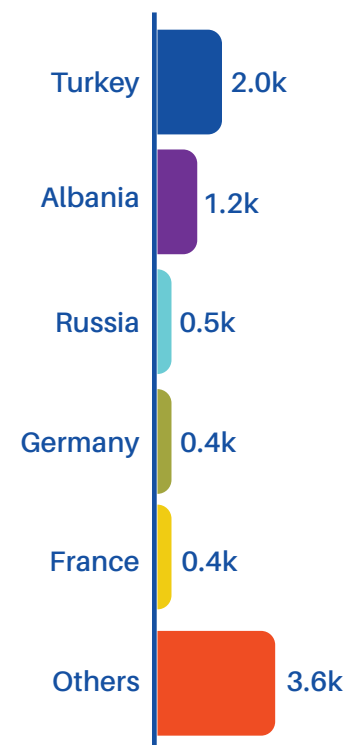
Work Visa



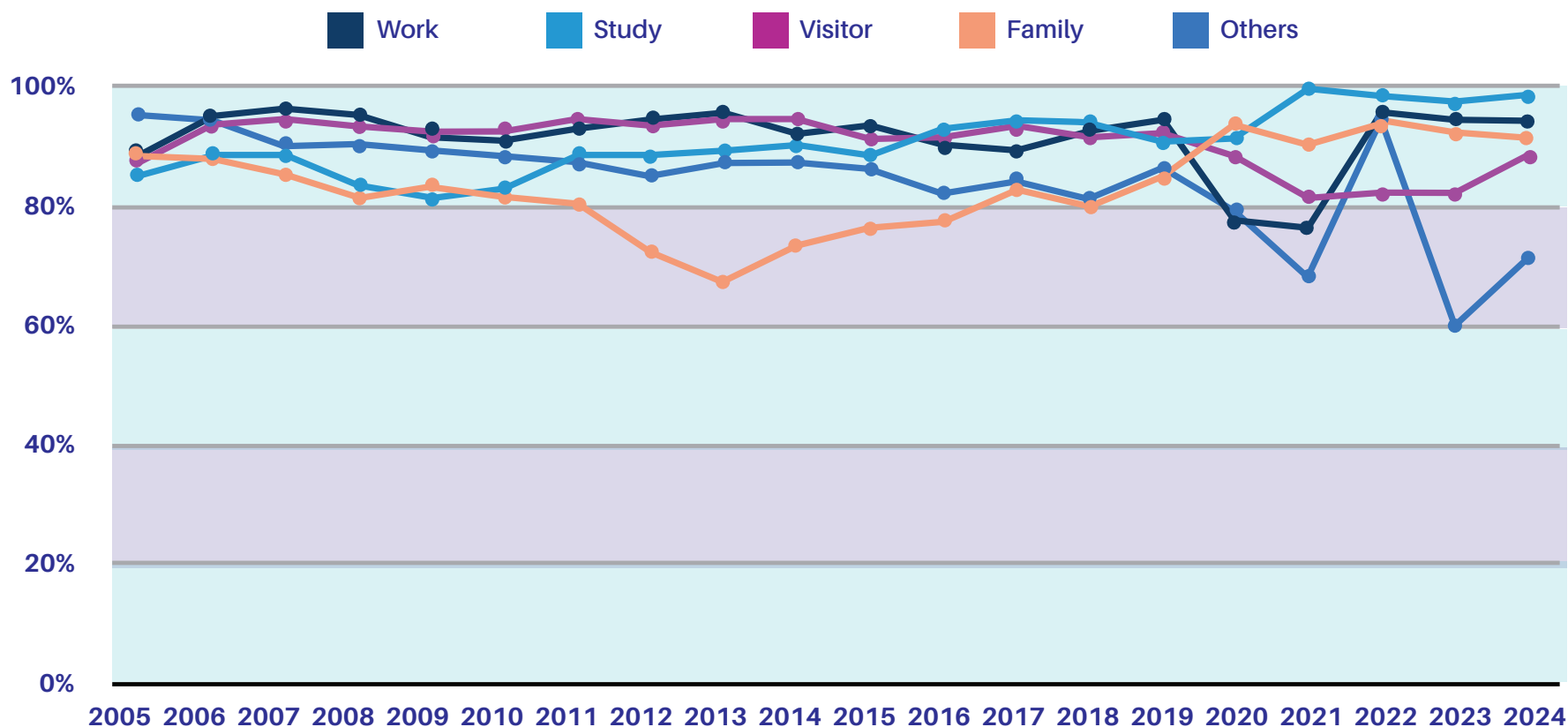
Study Visa



Family Visa

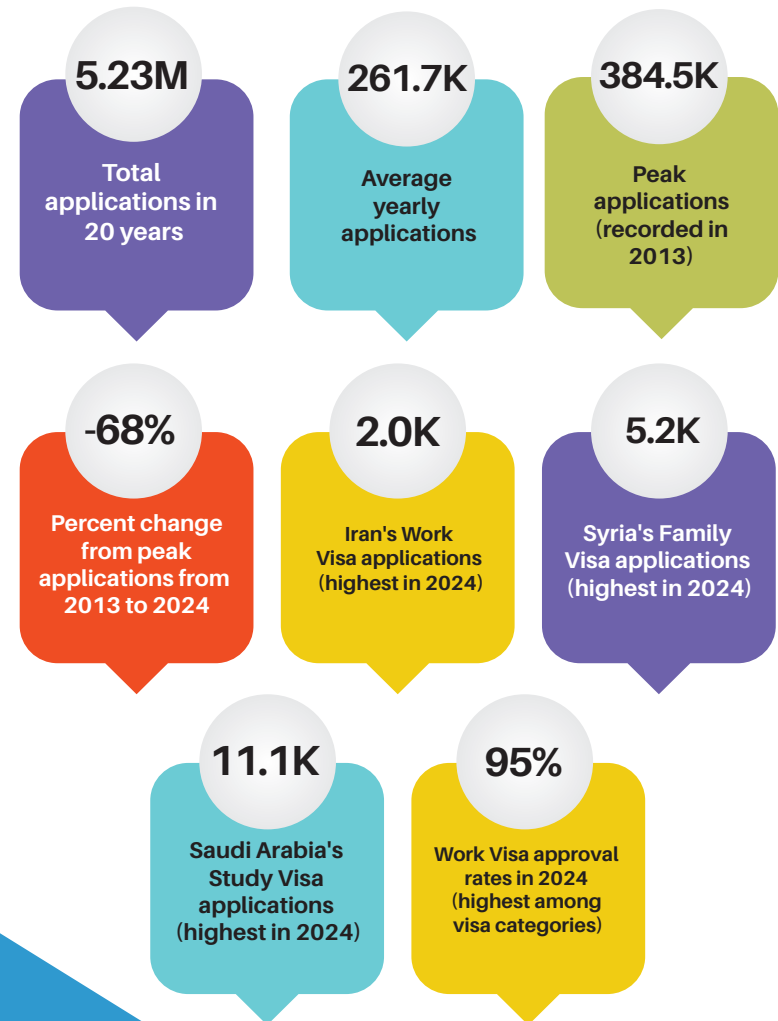
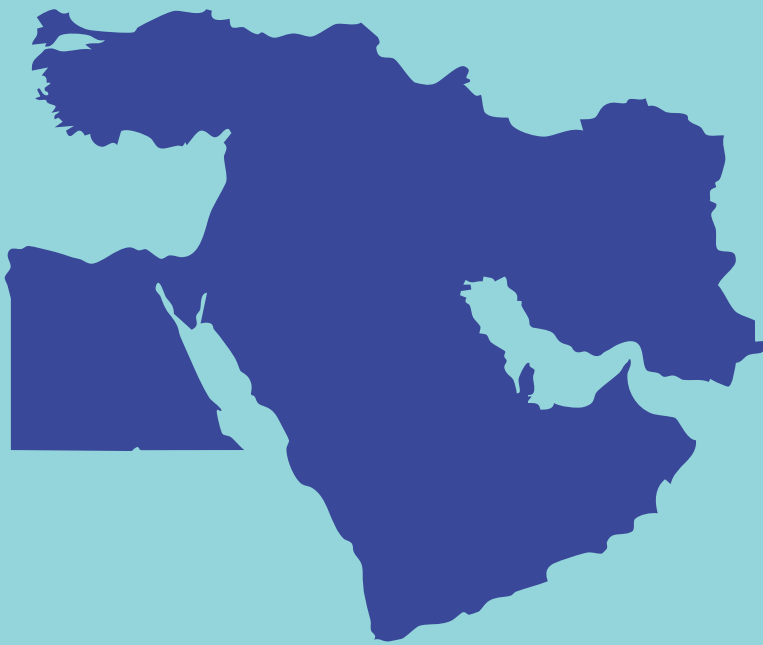


Europe: Approval Rates for each Visa Category (2005-2024)

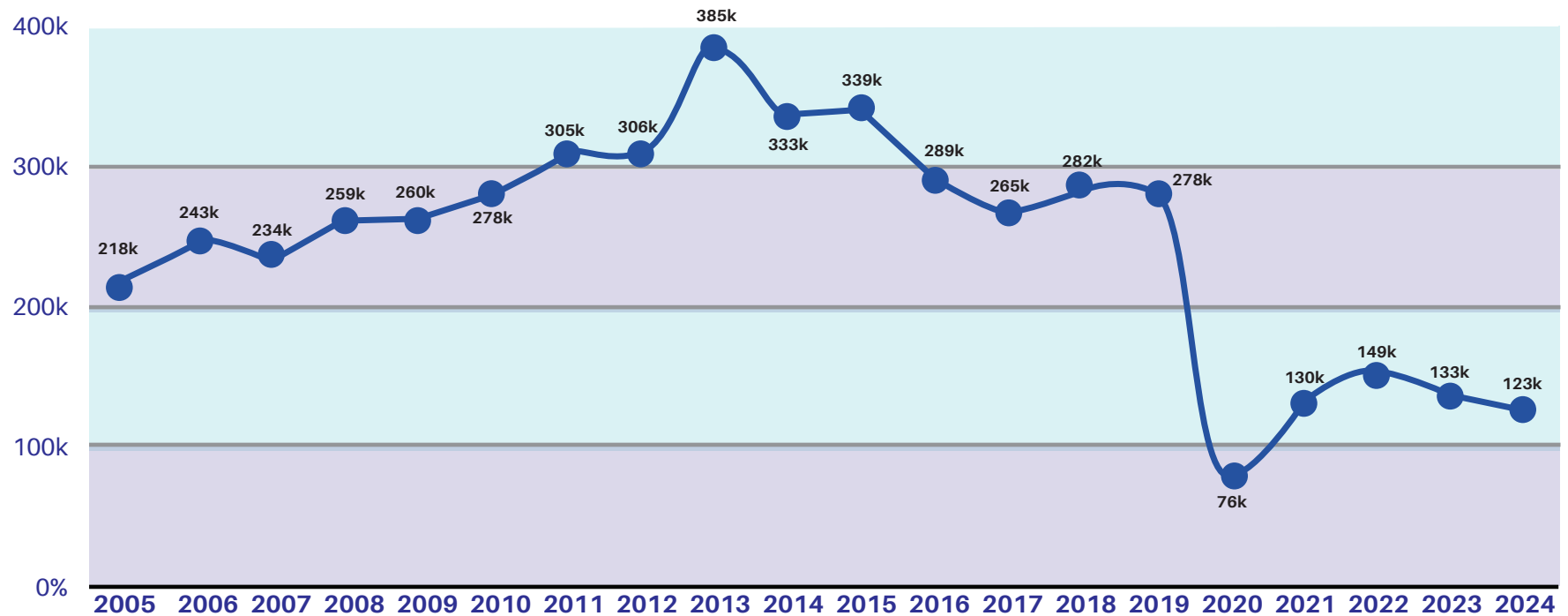


For European applicants, Work and Study Visas held up well over time—work hovered around 90%, and study approvals climbed to 98–99% between 2021 and 2024. Visitor Visas stayed strong too, mostly above 90%, though they dipped slightly post-2020. Family Visas were more up and down, dropping to 67% in 2013 but recovering to the 90s in recent years. Other visas showed the most volatility, sliding to 60% in 2023 before ticking up again. Overall, Europe kept high approval rates across most categories, with only a few dips along the way.

MIDDLE EAST - Key Figures

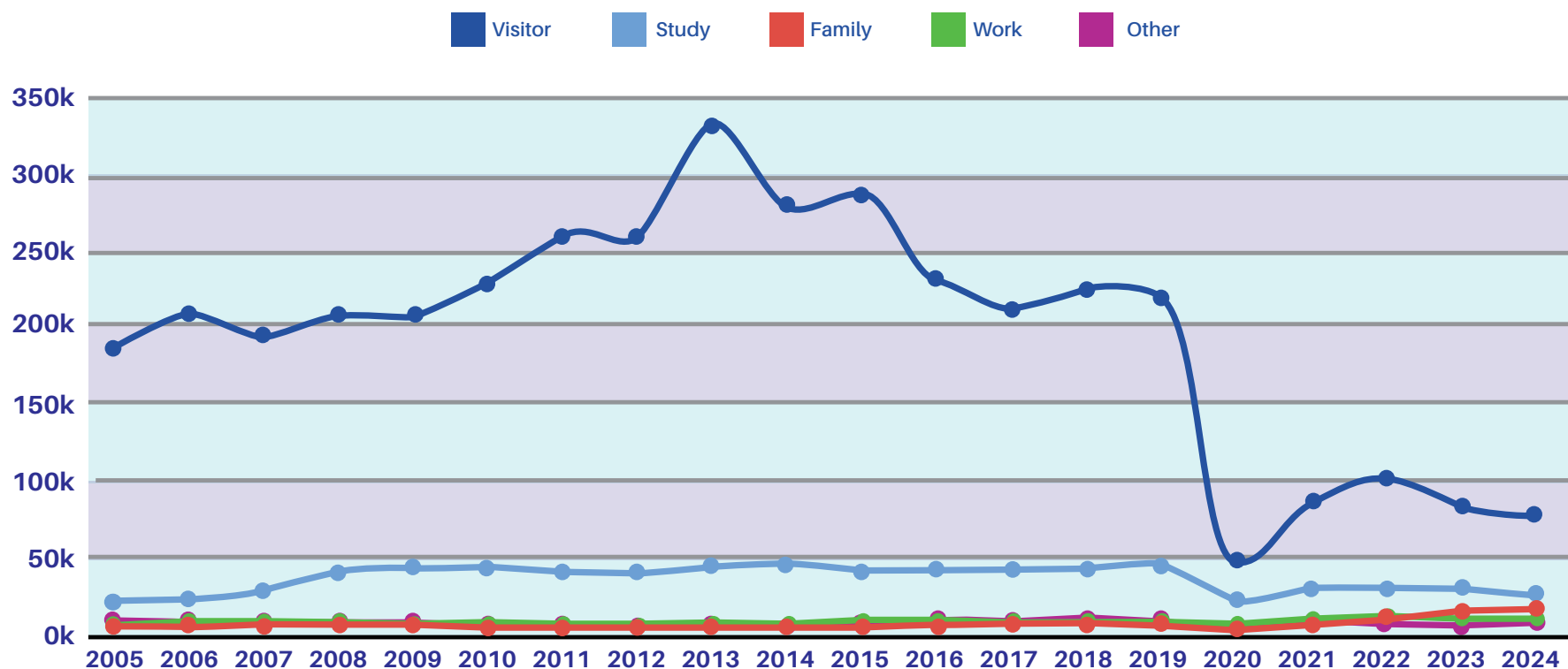


Middle East: UK Visa Applications (2005-2025)



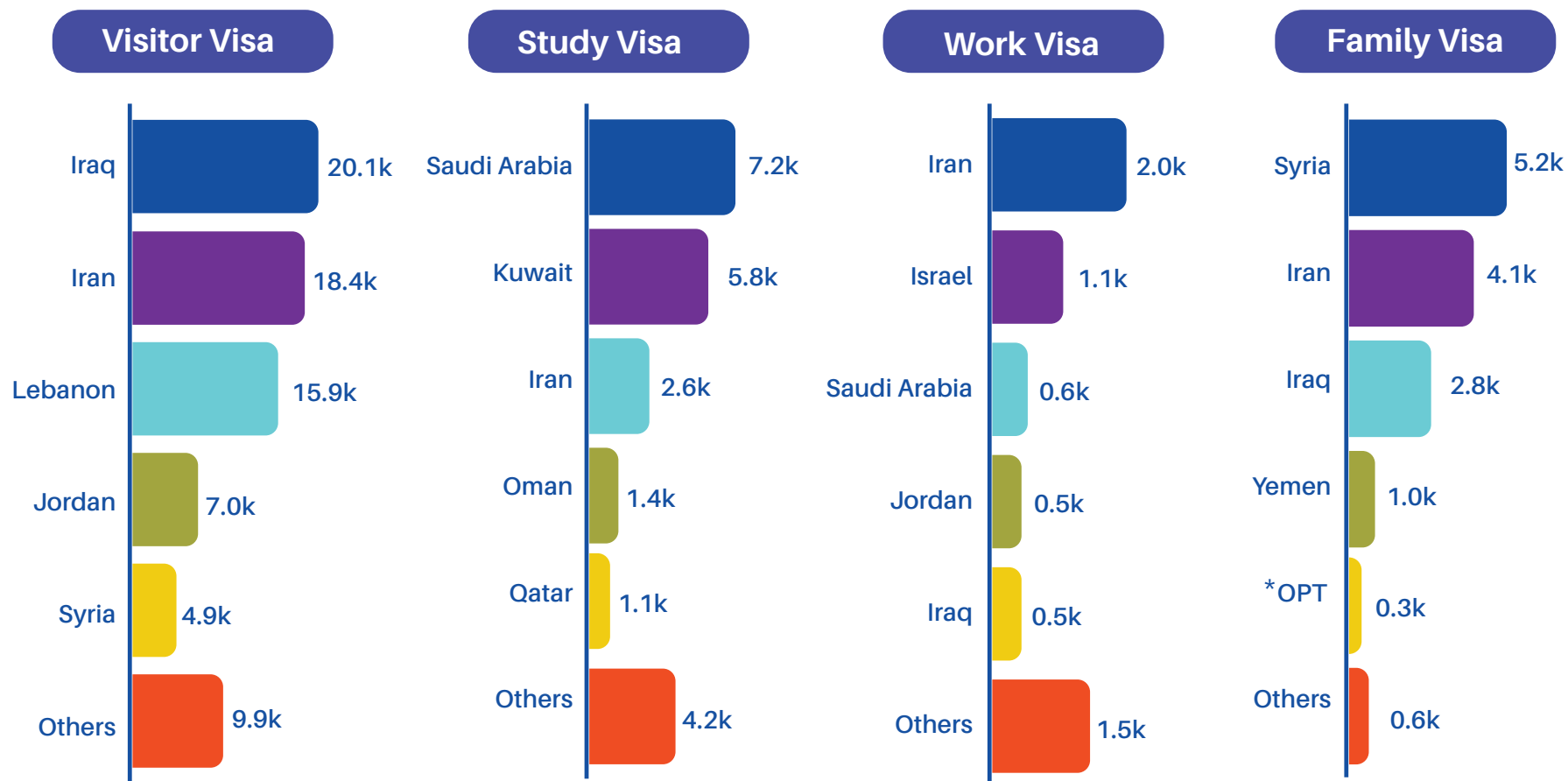
Applications from the Middle East peaked at 384,500 in 2013, after a steady climb from 218,000 in 2005. The following years saw a gradual decline, dipping to 75,500 in 2020 during the pandemic. Although there was a post-COVID rebound, volumes remained modest, reaching only 122,800 by 2024. This represents a 68% decline from the 2013 high. Unlike Africa and Asia, the Middle East hasn't experienced the same post-pandemic surge.

Middle East: UK Visa Applications by Category



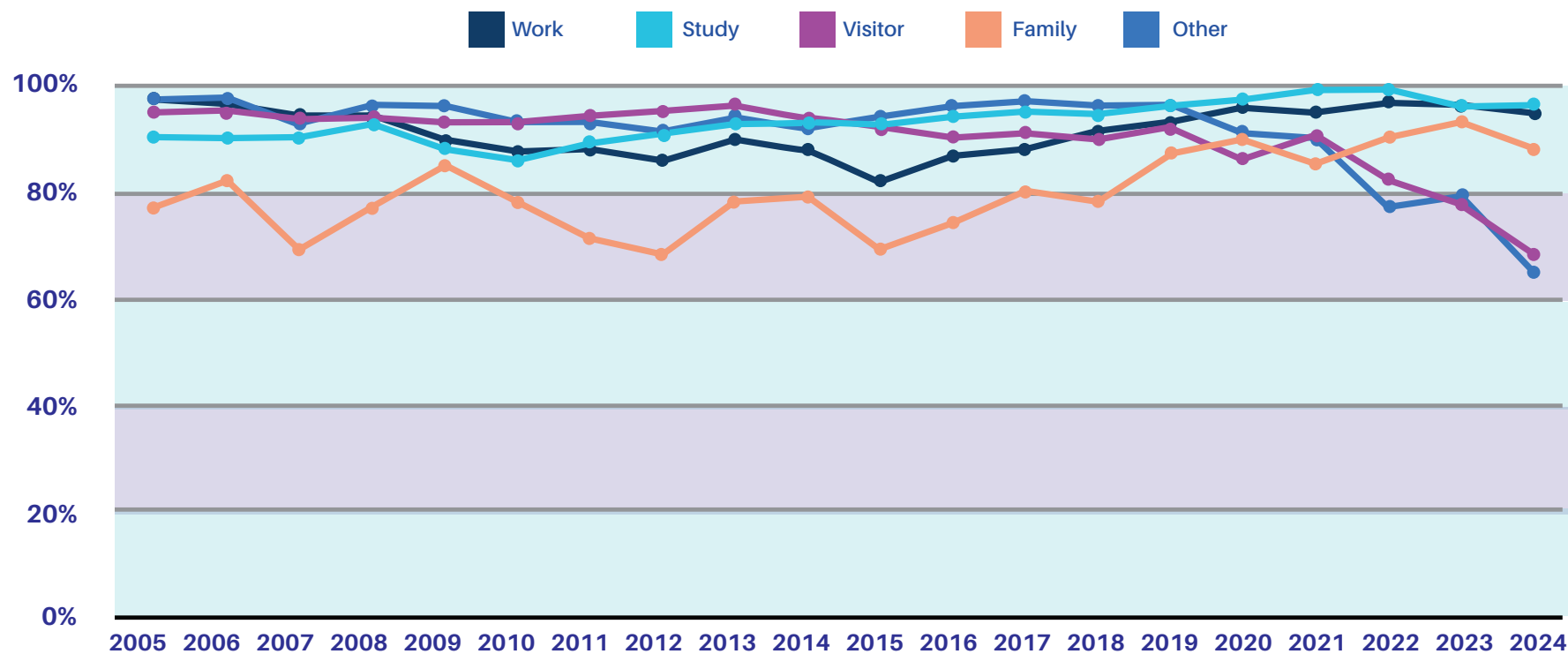
While overall applications from the Middle East have declined since 2013, Family Visa applications have grown significantly since 2020. From just 3,700 applications in 2020, the number rose to 13,900 by 2024 — a nearly 275% increase in four years. This stands out against a backdrop of stagnation in work and study routes and suggests a shift in the region's migration dynamics. The increase may reflect rising demand for reunification or more family-linked migration under humanitarian, sponsorship, or post-conflict mobility trends. Despite making up a small share of total Middle Eastern applications, Family Visas are now the region's fastest-growing category.

Top Countries in the Middle East by Visa Application Category in 2024



*OPT is short for Occupied Palestinian Territories

Middle East: Approval Rates by Visa Category (2005-2024)



Middle East applicants had it good with Work and Study Visas—hardly dipping below 90%, and study approvals even reaching 98%. But things weren't so rosy elsewhere. Visitor Visa approvals kept falling, from 94% in 2005 to just 67% by 2024. Family Visas had their ups and downs, and Other Visa types. They started strong but nose-dived to 64%. Basically, unless it's work or study, odds have gotten tougher.

OCEANIA - Key Figures



654.7K

Total applications
in 20 years
(2005-2024)

32.7K

Average
yearly
applications

52.1K

Peak applications
Recorded in 2005

-55%

Percent change
from peak
applications from
2013 to 2024

5.2K

Australia's Work
Visa applications
(highest in 2024)

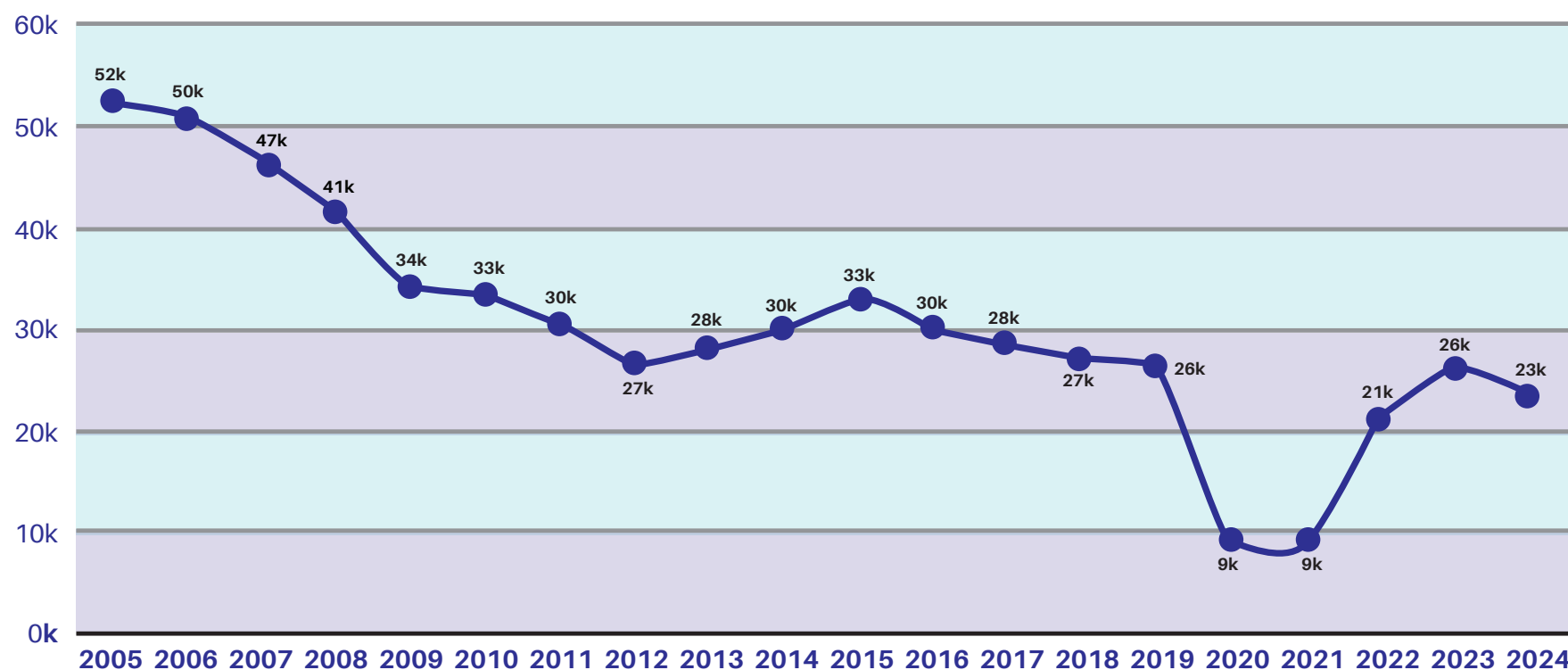
11.1K

Fiji's Visitor
Visa applications
(highest in 2024)

92.4%

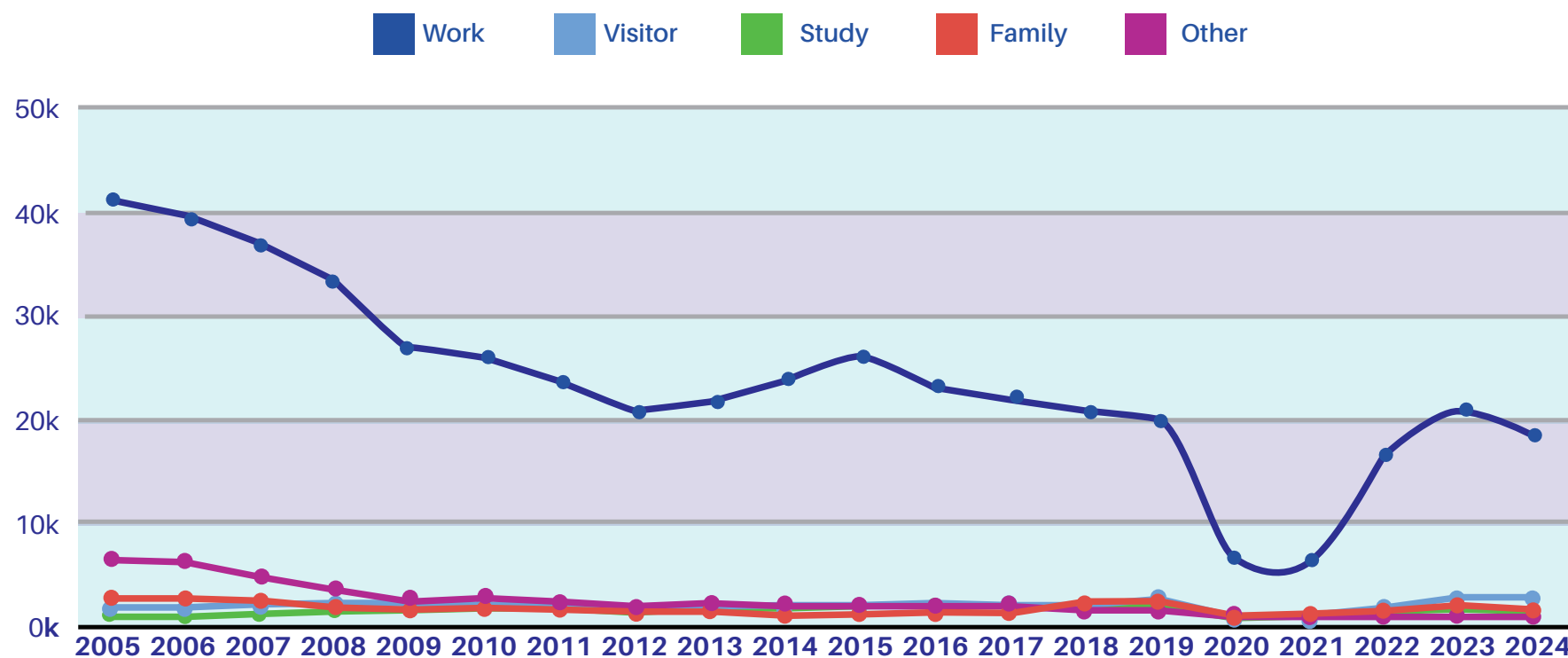
Study Visa
approval rate
(highest among
visa categories
in 2024)

Oceania: UK Visa Applications (2005-2024)



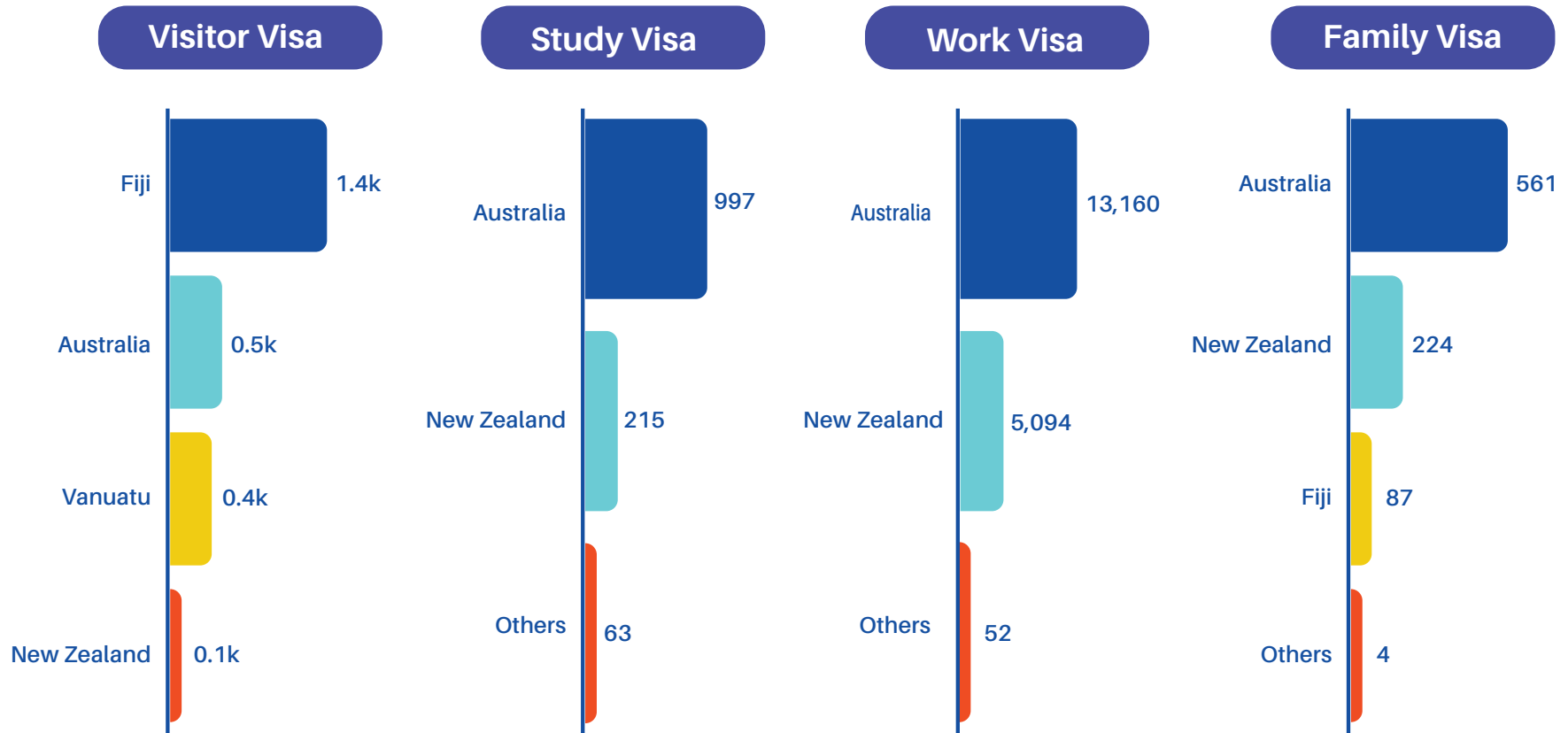
Applications from Oceania have steadily declined over the past two decades, dropping from 52,100 in 2005 to 26,100 in 2024—a 50% decrease. The sharpest drop occurred during the pandemic, with just 9,300 applications in 2020. While there was a modest rebound post-2021, volumes remain far below historic levels. This trend likely reflects reduced demand for UK Visas among citizens from Australia and New Zealand, who historically benefited from relaxed travel and work arrangements, and who may now favour countries with more streamlined bilateral mobility agreements.

Oceania: UK Visa Applications by Visa Category

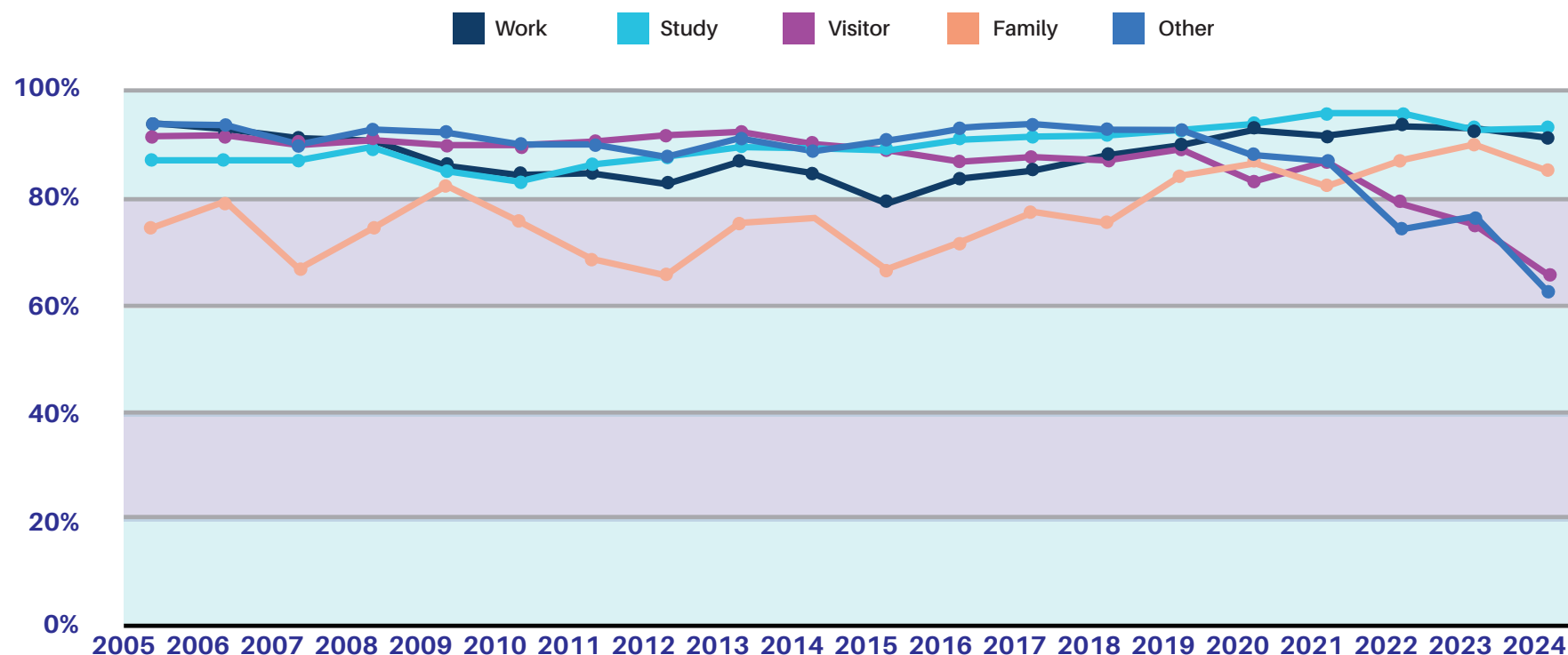


Oceania's visa applications have been dominated by Work Visas, which made up over 75% of the region's annual total through most of the years. Applications for Work Visas fell from 41,000 in 2005 to 18,300 in 2024, reflecting a long-term decline in mobility to the UK. Visitor, study, and family applications have remained consistently low, each rarely exceeding 2,000 per year. Despite a small rebound after 2021, the region's total application volume remains less than half of what it was in 2005, highlighting shifting migration patterns and possibly greater attraction to countries like Canada and Australia offering more favorable mobility schemes.

Top Countries in Oceania by Visa Category in 2024



Oceania: UK Visa Applications by Visa Category (2005-2024)



Work and Study Visas from Oceania kept strong approval rates—often above 90%—with study peaking at 98% around 2021-2022. Visitor Visa approvals, though once high at 94%, slid steadily down to 67% by 2024. Family Visas moved up and down but peaked at 92% in 2023, while Other visas dropped sharply to 64%. Overall, UK visa success for Oceania stayed high in work and study, but other categories clearly lost ground.

Methodology

- All visa applications and issuances data used in this report was obtained from the UK Home Office's Entry Clearance Visa Applications and Outcomes datasets, covering the period from 2005 to 2024.
- Details of UK immigration policy and legislative changes referenced in this report were sourced from the official Policy and Legislative Changes Affecting Migration to the UK: Timeline, published by the UK Home Office.
- To forecast UK visa application volumes for the six quarters spanning Q3 2025- Q4 2026, a Seasonal ARIMA (SARIMA) model was fitted to historical quarterly data from 2005-2024, with anomalies such as the 2020 Q2-2021 Q2 COVID shock smoothed by interpolation.

Automated model selection identified SARIMA(1,0,1)(0,1,2)[4] as the best fit, based on information criteria and residual diagnostics. The resulting forecasts project quarterly volumes of roughly 600,000 to just over 1 million, with the established seasonal peaks in Q2 and Q3 expected to persist through 2026.



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